

# Faith After Deconstruction

*How to Lose the Faith You Were Given and Find the One  
That Holds*

James Bell

LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*I believe, help my unbelief.*

— A father, to Jesus, in Mark 9

# Introduction: The Sound a Faith Makes When It Comes Apart

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I want to tell you about the night I stopped praying and did not tell anyone. It was not dramatic. There was no crisis of the kind that gets written about later, no funeral, no betrayal I could point to and say, there, that is the wound. I was a pastor. I had a Bible open on the desk in front of me and a sermon due in three days, and I sat in the quiet of a church office at eleven at night and realized I had been talking to the ceiling for a long time. The words still came. The words were fine. I could have preached that Sunday and no one would have known. But somewhere underneath the words a floor had gone soft, and I could feel myself standing on something that had begun, very slowly, to give.

That is the sound a faith makes when it comes apart. Not a crash. A settling. The small groan of a house adjusting to a foundation that has shifted an inch, and then another inch, until the doors no longer close the way they used to. Most people who are losing their faith do not lose it the way movies show it, in a single blaze of anger against God. They lose it the way you lose your hearing, gradually and then all at once, and one day they notice that the thing they used to be sure of has been replaced by the memory of being sure. The certainty is gone. What is left is the shape of where it was.

I did not come to faith the easy way, and I think that matters for the pages ahead. I was an atheist. Not a soft one, not the kind who still lit candles at Christmas and felt something. I thought

the whole apparatus of God was a comfort humans built against the dark, a story we told because the alternative, that we are alone and briefly here and then not, was more than most people could carry. I came to Christ as a grown man, against my own arguments, dragged by something I could not name into a room I had spent years mocking from the outside. So when my faith later came apart in that office, I already knew the country on the other side. I had lived there. Unbelief was not a foreign land I was afraid of. It was home, once. That is the strange gift of a late conversion. You are never fully able to pretend the questions are unthinkable, because you used to think them, and they did not feel like sin. They felt like honesty.

There is a word for what happened to me, and it is a word the church has learned to say with fear. Deconstruction. It has become a battle line. On one side are the people leaving, tearing down the faith they were raised in, posting their reasons, finding each other in the wreckage, relieved to be out. On the other side are the people who stayed, watching their children and their friends and sometimes their pastors walk away, and reaching, in their fear, for the only tools they know. They call it rebellion. They call it a slippery slope. They quote the verse about people whose ears itch for what they want to hear, and they build the walls higher, and they cannot understand why the higher walls make more people climb over. I have stood on both sides of that line. I have been the one leaving and the one afraid of the leaving. And I have come to believe that almost everyone involved has misunderstood what is actually happening.

Here is what I have come to believe, and this book is the long argument for it. Some deconstruction is faithful. Not all of it. But some of the tearing down that terrifies the church is the Spirit of God doing exactly what the Spirit of God has always done,

which is to pull down what cannot bear weight so that something that can might be built in its place. The faith many of us were handed was not the pure gospel. It was the gospel fused with a thousand other things, a culture, a politics, a set of fears, a way of controlling children, a certainty about matters God never made certain. And when a person begins to pull at that fused mass, they are often not pulling at Christ. They are pulling at the packaging. The tragedy is that we taught them the packaging was Christ, so when it comes off in their hands they think they are holding the death of God, when what they are actually holding is the death of a idol they were told to worship.

I am not going to flatter you. If you are deconstructing because it is easier, because faith asks more of your life than you want to give and doubt gives you a respectable exit, I am not going to pretend that is the Spirit. There is a demolition that ends in nothing, that mistakes the removal of every wall for freedom and then stands, exposed, in a field with no house and calls the exposure honesty. I have watched people take apart a fragile faith and build nothing, and I have watched what happens to a soul that lives too long in the rubble. It is not liberation. It is a slow forgetting of how to hope. So I am not here to hand you a permission slip. I am here to make a distinction the church has been too frightened to make, between the deconstruction that clears ground and the deconstruction that only clears out.

You should know what I will not do in this book. I will not shame you for your questions. The questions are not the enemy, and treating them as the enemy is how the church lost so many of the people it now grieves. If you are asking why a God of love would command the slaughter of children in the book of Joshua, that is not a sign of a hard heart. It is a sign that your heart is working. If you are asking why the people who taught you about

Jesus covered up abuse, or backed a politics of cruelty, or told you your body was shameful before you were old enough to know what a body was for, you are not being rebellious. You are being honest about harm that was real. I will take those questions seriously, one at a time, without the trick of answering a question you did not ask because the one you did ask frightens me.

And I will not lie to you about the other side of it either. There is a load-bearing faith on the far side of the tearing down, but it is not the one that fell. That is the thing almost no one says out loud. You do not get the old house back. The people who tell you that you can rebuild exactly what you had, brick for brick, are selling you a nostalgia that will crack the first time real weight comes down on it. What is on the other side is different. It is smaller in some ways, in that it no longer claims to know things it never knew. It is larger in others, in that it can hold suffering and doubt and mystery without shattering. It is a faith that has been through the fire and does not need you to protect it anymore, because it has already survived the worst thing you could think.

So this is a book about losing the faith you were given, and it is a book about finding the one that holds. Those are not the same faith, and pretending they are is the first lie I want to clear out of the way. The father in the ninth chapter of Mark comes to Jesus with a son he cannot heal and a hope he cannot quite hold, and he says the truest sentence in the Gospels. I believe, help my unbelief. He does not resolve the contradiction. He carries both halves of it into the presence of Christ and lays them down, and Jesus does not scold him for the second half. Jesus heals the boy. That man is the patron saint of everyone reading this. He is the one who stopped pretending he was sure, and found that the not-being-sure was not a wall between him and God. It was the

doorway. That is where we are going. Come in through the door  
you thought was a wall.

# Chapter One: The Faith That Fell

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Let me start with the honest scene, because everything in this book depends on you trusting that I will not look away from it. A woman I will not name sat across from me in the small room off the sanctuary where I take the conversations no one wants to have in the hallway. She was in her thirties. She had grown up in the church, the good kind of church by every external measure, the kind with a functioning youth group and a missions budget and a pastor who did not steal. She had done everything right. She had signed the purity pledge at fourteen and kept it. She had gone to the Christian college. She had married a Christian man in a ceremony that quoted the right verses. And she sat in that room and told me, in a voice with no drama left in it, that she did not believe any of it anymore and she had not for two years and she was only telling me now because she was tired of performing on Sunday mornings for a God she had stopped being able to find.

I asked her what happened. I have learned to ask that question and then to be quiet for a long time, because the answer is never the first thing that comes out. The first thing is usually the intellectual reason, the tidy one, the one that sounds respectable. She gave me that one. She had read some things about how the Bible was assembled, about the councils and the arguments and the books that did not make the cut, and it had shaken her sense that the thing was dropped from heaven whole. Fine. That is a real reason and we will get to it. But I waited, because I have learned that the intellectual reason is usually the door and not the room. And after a while she told me the real thing, which was



that when she was nineteen a man in that church had done something to her that no one should do to anyone, and when she finally told a leader about it, the leader had asked her what she had been wearing.

That is the faith that fell. Not a faith undone by an argument. A faith undone by a floor that gave way at the exact moment she put her full weight on it. The whole structure had promised her that if she followed the rules, she would be safe and she would be held and God would be near. She followed the rules. She was not safe. She was not held. And when she looked for God in the aftermath, what she found instead was a man asking about her clothing. You cannot argue a person out of that. You cannot hand her a book about the reliability of the New Testament and expect it to reach the place where the damage lives. The intellectual questions were real, but they were also the socially acceptable clothing she put on a wound she did not yet have words for.

I tell you her story first because the church keeps making the same mistake about why people leave, and the mistake is not innocent. The church prefers to believe people leave for intellectual reasons, because intellectual reasons can be answered with intellectual arguments, and intellectual arguments do not require the church to change. If she left because she read the wrong book, the solution is to give her the right book, and the institution never has to look at itself. But if she left because the institution failed her at the one moment it promised it would not, then the answer is not a book. The answer is repentance, and repentance is the one thing frightened institutions are worst at. So we tell ourselves the comfortable story. We say the culture got to her. We say she wanted to sin. We say anything except the true thing, which is that we asked her what she was wearing.

My own faith did not fall for her reason. I want to be careful

here, because it would be a kind of theft for me to borrow the drama of other people's wounds. Mine fell more quietly, and for reasons that were, at least at first, more like the tidy door than the room behind it. I had built my adult faith, my convert's faith, on a certain confidence that Christianity simply explained the world better than the atheism I had left. It answered the questions. It made sense of beauty and evil and the strange fact of consciousness. And for years that held, because I kept it away from the hardest evidence, the way you keep a good mood away from the news. But I was a pastor. My job was to sit with the hardest evidence. I sat with the parents of a child who died at four of something no one could have stopped. I sat with a man dying slowly and afraid. I read the Old Testament all the way through instead of just the parts that preach, and I found a God in some of those pages I did not recognize and did not like. And the confidence, the it-all-makes-sense confidence, began to give.

What fell for me was not belief in God. It was belief in the version of God I had been handed and then handed to others. I had been preaching a God who was, if I am honest, a little too manageable. A God whose ways were mysterious in the abstract but reliably comprehensible in the particular. A God who could be trusted to make suffering make sense, if not now then later, in a way that would satisfy. And when I sat in enough rooms with enough suffering that did not make sense and showed no sign of ever making sense, that God died. I do not know how else to say it. The God I had built died in those rooms, and for a while I thought that meant God had died, because I had made the fatal error of confusing my picture of God with God. That is the error at the center of almost every deconstruction, and I will come back to it many times, because naming it is the first step out of the rubble.

Here is what I have learned to say to the woman in that room, and to myself in that office years ago, and to you if this is where you are. The thing that fell needed to fall. I do not mean the harm was good. God forbid. I mean that the faith which promised her safety in exchange for obedience was a false faith, a transaction dressed as a covenant, and it was going to fail her eventually because it was built to fail. It made God into a vending machine that dispensed protection for the coin of good behavior, and a vending machine God cannot survive contact with a world where good people are not protected. When that faith fell, it was not her rebellion. It was the collapse of a lie she had been sold as the truth. The tragedy is not that it fell. The tragedy is that it was built.

And so the first thing I want to say to anyone standing in the wreckage of a fallen faith is a thing that will sound strange coming from a pastor. Do not rush to rebuild it. Do not let anyone, including your own frightened heart, hand you the old blueprints and tell you to put it back exactly as it was. If it fell because it was false, then rebuilding it identically is just scheduling the next collapse. There is a grief that has to happen first, a real grief, because something died and you are allowed to mourn it even if it needed to die. I have stood at funerals for people who did great harm, and watched their families weep, and understood that you can grieve a thing and still know it was time. You can grieve the faith that fell. You should. But do not resurrect the corpse. What God has in mind for you is not resuscitation. It is resurrection, and resurrection, in the only case that matters, produced a body that the disciples did not at first recognize.

The woman in that room did not come back to the faith she left. I want to be honest about that, because I am not writing a book

that ends with everyone returning to their pews, chastened and grateful. She never went back to that church, and she was right not to. But over a long time, longer than I wanted it to take, she came to something else. She came to a God who was not the vending machine, who did not promise her a safety He never actually promised anyone, who instead had a Son who was Himself not kept safe, who was Himself failed by the institution of His day and asked, in effect, what He had been wearing. She found her way to the crucified God, the one who does not answer suffering from a safe distance but enters it. And that God she could believe in, because that God was not disproved by her wound. That God was standing inside it.

*The faith that promised you safety was always going to fail you, because it was a transaction wearing the costume of a covenant.*

That is where we begin. Not with the reassurance that your faith will come back the way it was, because it will not, and you would not want the thing that fell if you saw clearly what it was made of. We begin with permission to let it stay fallen long enough to see what it was actually built on. Some of you have been holding the rubble in your hands, ashamed, thinking the wreckage is proof of your failure. It is not. Sometimes the wreckage is proof that you were finally strong enough to stop holding up a wall that was never load-bearing to begin with. Set it down. We have a long way to walk, and you cannot walk it carrying a house that already fell.

## Chapter Two: The Packaging and the Gift

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There is a thing that happens when you buy something expensive and fragile. It arrives wrapped in more material than the thing itself. There is the box, and inside the box there is foam, and inside the foam there is paper, and somewhere in the center of all that protection is the small object you actually paid for. And if you are not careful, if you are a child or you are in a hurry, you can throw the whole thing out together. The gift and the packaging go into the trash as one mass, and only later, digging through the garbage, do you realize the thing you wanted was buried in the material meant to protect it. That is the closest picture I have for what happens to most people's faith, and I want to spend this chapter on it, because if you understand this one thing, half of what feels like losing God will turn out to be losing something else.

The faith you were handed was not pure gospel. It could not have been. There is no such thing as pure gospel handed from one human being to another, because the gospel always arrives wrapped in a culture, and the culture is the only way it can travel. When Paul preached in Athens he quoted their poets. When the missionaries came to my ancestors they came speaking a particular language, carrying a particular set of assumptions about music and clothing and the shape of a proper family, and they could not have done otherwise, because human beings are not disembodied. We receive everything through a medium. The problem is not that the gospel came to you wrapped in a culture. That is unavoidable. The problem is that no one ever taught you

to tell the difference between the gift and the wrapping, and so you grew up believing that the whole package, foam and paper and box, was the sacred thing.

Let me be specific, because vagueness here is a kind of cowardice. In the church that raised many of you, a particular politics came wrapped around the gospel so tightly that you could not tell where one ended and the other began. A certain party was the Christian party. A certain set of positions on a certain set of issues was simply what a believer believed, and to question the positions was to question Christ. You were taught that a specific vision of the family, breadwinning father and homemaking mother, was not one arrangement among several that Christians have lived in across two thousand years but the biblical arrangement, ordained, non-negotiable. You were taught that a specific style of music was reverent and another was worldly, that a specific way of dressing was modest and godly, that a specific set of behaviors marked the saved from the lost. And all of it came stamped with the authority of God, so that when you later came to doubt the politics or the family model or the dress code, it felt like doubting God, because you had never been given the tools to pull them apart.

This is why so much deconstruction is actually a person tearing at the packaging while screaming that they have lost the gift. They pull at the politics and it feels like pulling at Christ. They pull at the culture-war certainties and it feels like the whole thing is coming down, because the whole thing was fused into one mass in their formation. And the people watching them, the ones still inside, see them pulling at the mass and cry out that they are destroying their faith, when in fact what is being destroyed is a wad of foam and paper that was never the gift. I have watched a young man throw out the entire New Testament because he could

no longer stomach the cruelty he saw in the people who had taught it to him, and I have wanted to reach into the trash and pull the small object back out and say, not this, you can throw the rest out but not this. But he could not hear the distinction, because no one ever gave it to him.

The scholar Lesslie Newbigin, who spent decades as a missionary in India before returning to a post-Christian England in the nineteen-seventies, understood this better than almost anyone. He saw that the gospel is never encountered outside of some culture, that there is no acultural Christianity floating free, and that the great danger is not the wrapping itself but the failure to know it is wrapping. A gospel that has forgotten it is wearing a cultural costume will mistake the costume for the body, and it will defend the costume with the ferocity it should reserve for the body. That is the church that raised many of you. It defended the wrapping to the death. It treated a challenge to its cultural forms as a challenge to God, and in doing so it taught a whole generation that to question the culture was to lose the faith. Then that generation questioned the culture, as every generation does, and lost the faith, exactly as they had been trained to.

I have to implicate myself here, because I did this. In my early years of ministry I preached the wrapping as though it were the gift. I had my list of things a serious Christian did and did not do, and some of them were genuinely from Christ and some of them were from my own culture and my own fear and my own need to feel that I was on the right side of a line, and I did not always know which was which. I told people things about how they should vote and how they should dress and what music revealed about the state of a soul, and I said it all in the same voice, the voice of certainty, the voice that does not distinguish. I handed people the whole box and told them it was the gift. And

some of those people have since thrown the whole box away, and I cannot entirely blame them, because I am the one who taught them not to tell the difference.

So how do you tell the difference. That is the question this whole book is trying to answer, and I am not going to pretend there is a simple test, but I can give you a beginning. The gift is the thing that runs through every culture the gospel has ever entered and comes out the other side recognizable. The wrapping is the thing that only appears in your culture, or your century, or your particular tribe. The resurrection of Jesus is the gift. It is claimed by Ethiopian Christians in the fourth century and Korean Christians in the twentieth and it is the same claim, a body that was dead and then was not. A particular American political alignment is not the gift. It did not exist for nineteen of the twenty centuries of the church and it does not exist in most of the places the church lives now, which is a sign, a strong sign, that it is wrapping and not gift. When you find yourself doubting something, ask first whether the thing you are doubting is claimed by the church across all its times and places or whether it is a local costume. You will be surprised how often the thing that feels like the center turns out to be the wrapping.

I said in the last chapter that the faith which fell needed to fall, and here is the deeper version of that claim. What needs to fall is the fusion. The tragedy of the inherited faith is not that it contained cultural wrapping, because all faith does, but that it welded the wrapping to the gift and called the weld holy. Deconstruction, at its best, is the fire that melts the weld. It is painful, and it looks like destruction, and to the people watching it is indistinguishable from apostasy. But when the weld melts, the wrapping falls away from the gift, and for the first time you can see them as two different things. That is a gift the settled



believer often never receives. The person who has never had their faith come apart may go their whole life unable to tell the gospel from their grandmother's politics, and they will defend both with the same breath, and they will die never having met the naked gift underneath. There is a knowledge available on the far side of the fire that is not available to those who never walked into it.

*You did not lose the gift. You lost the box it came in, and you have been grieving cardboard.*

But I have to say the hard half of this too, because a chapter that only comforts is a chapter that lies. Sometimes the fire that melts the weld does not stop at the weld. Sometimes it keeps burning, and it takes the gift too, and the person walks out of the fire holding nothing at all, having decided that if the wrapping was false the gift must be false as well. This is the leap that ends in the empty field. You reason, correctly, that the politics were not the gospel, and then you reason, incorrectly, that therefore there is no gospel, that it was all wrapping all the way down, that when you have peeled every cultural layer there is nothing in the center but the human need that generated the layers. I understand the appeal of that conclusion. I held it for years, as an atheist, and it has the clean feeling of a room swept empty. But it is a conclusion, not a discovery. It is a thing you decide, not a thing you find, and the honest deconstructor has to notice the difference between finding that the center is empty and deciding in advance that it must be. Most people who quit at the empty field never actually looked for the gift. They threw out the box without ever digging through it, and then reported that there was nothing inside.

So this is the work, and it is patient work, and it cannot be rushed. You have to go back through the trash. You have to take

the mass of your inherited faith and pull it apart layer by layer, and hold each piece up to the light, and ask of it, is this the gift or is this the box. The politics, the box, throw it out. The certainty about the age of the earth, probably the box, set it aside. The shame about your body, that is not even good box, that is a thing someone put in the box that was never supposed to be there at all, get rid of it. And then, near the center, you will start to reach things that do not come apart so easily, things that are claimed everywhere the church has ever been, the crucified God, the empty tomb, the grace that does not depend on your performance, the strange durable insistence that love is stronger than death. Those are not box. Handle those differently. Those are what you were digging for. That is the gift, and it was there the whole time, buried in the packaging you were told to worship, waiting for someone honest enough to tear the wrapping to find it.

## Chapter Three: Two Kinds of Tearing Down

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I need to draw a line now, and it is the most important line in the book, and I have been dreading writing this chapter because the line is real but it does not fall where either side wants it to fall. There are two kinds of tearing down. There is the tearing down that clears ground for building, and there is the tearing down that clears out and calls the emptiness freedom. They can look identical from the outside. They often use the same words, ask the same questions, leave the same churches. But they are moving in opposite directions, and the difference between them is not the questions they ask. It is what they are willing to do with the answers.

Let me name the faithless kind first, and let me do it without the sneer the church usually brings to this, because the sneer is how we lose the ability to see clearly. Faithless deconstruction is not deconstruction done by bad people. It is deconstruction that has quietly decided the outcome before it begins. It asks its questions the way a man asks his wife where she was last night when he has already made up his mind she was unfaithful. The questions are not open. They are the polite form of an accusation, and no answer could satisfy them, because satisfaction was never the goal. The goal was the exit, and the questions are the corridor to the exit, dressed as an investigation. I know this pattern because I have run it myself, in my atheist years, when I would ask a believer some hard thing about suffering not because I wanted their answer but because I wanted to watch them fail to give one. That is not honest inquiry. That is a trial with a verdict already

written.

You can tell the faithless kind by a certain relief that runs underneath it. There is a lightness that comes when a person decides God is not real, and I do not mock that lightness, because I felt it, and it is genuine. If there is no God then there is no judgment, and no demand, and no one keeping account of the life you are living, and for a person carrying shame or exhaustion that can feel like a window thrown open in a stale room. But notice what that lightness reveals. It reveals that the deconstruction was serving a want. The person wanted the demand to be gone, and doubt gave them a respectable way to be rid of it. They did not follow the questions to wherever the questions led. They followed the questions to where they already wanted to go, and the intellectual apparatus was the vehicle, not the driver. That is the tell. When the conclusion arrives with relief instead of grief, it usually means the conclusion was the destination all along.

Now the faithful kind, and this is harder to describe because it does not feel good while it is happening. Faithful deconstruction tears down with grief, not relief. It does not want the thing to be false. It is often desperate for the thing to be true, and it is precisely that desperation that drives it to test the structure, because a person who loves a house will be the one who insists on checking whether the beam is rotten. The faithless kind wants the beam to be rotten so it can leave. The faithful kind is terrified the beam is rotten and checks anyway, because it would rather know the truth than live in a house that might come down on the people it loves. Do you see the difference. It is not in the checking. Both of them check. It is in what they are hoping to find, and in what they are willing to do if the beam turns out to be sound.

Barbara Brown Taylor, in her book *Learning to Walk in the Dark*, published in twenty-fourteen, writes about what she calls the solar spirituality that dominates the church, the relentless insistence on light and certainty and answers, and she argues for a lunar spirituality that can find God in the dark, that does not need the lights on to believe someone is in the room. I have found no better description of what faithful deconstruction is actually doing. It is not turning off the lights to prove no one is home. It is learning to be in the room when the lights go off and to stop assuming that the darkness means abandonment. The faithless kind flips the switch and, finding the room dark, concludes it is empty and leaves. The faithful kind sits in the dark and waits, and this is the crucial thing, keeps waiting, does not use the darkness as a reason to go. It stays in the unknowing. That staying is faith. Not certainty. Staying.

Here is where I have to disappoint the gatekeepers, though, because they want me to say that the faithful kind ends up believing all the same things it started with, and it does not. Faithful deconstruction can lead a person to abandon beliefs they held sincerely and were taught were essential. It can lead them out of a particular reading of Genesis, or a particular doctrine of hell, or a particular certainty about who is in and who is out. The gatekeeper hears that and says, there, you see, it led them astray, it is the faithless kind after all. But that is exactly the confusion this book exists to correct. Faithfulness is not measured by whether you kept every belief you started with. It is measured by whether you were following the truth or fleeing the demand. A person can lose a great many inherited beliefs in complete faithfulness, because some of those beliefs were false, and losing a false belief is not apostasy. It is repentance. The faithful deconstructor sometimes ends up believing fewer things and believing them more deeply, and the gatekeeper cannot tell that

apart from apostasy because the gatekeeper counts beliefs instead of weighing them.

Let me give you the two people, because the abstraction needs flesh. I have known both. The first is a man who came apart after his daughter was diagnosed with something terrible, and he tore into his faith with a fury that frightened his family, reading everything, arguing with me for hours, refusing every easy comfort I offered and rightly so, because the easy comforts were insults to what he was carrying. He looked, from outside, exactly like a man losing his faith. He was, in fact, a man refusing to lose it cheaply. He would not accept a God who was a lie, and so he tore at every part of God that might be a lie, and what he could not tear away, what held under all that fury, became the only thing he had left and the only thing he needed. He believes now. He believes less than he did and he believes it in his bones, and his belief could survive his daughter's death, which the old belief could not have, because the old belief depended on her getting better.

The second is a woman who left, and I want to be fair to her, because her leaving was not frivolous and I am not going to caricature her. But over the years I watched what her deconstruction was actually made of, and underneath the questions, which were real questions, was a steady unwillingness to let anything have authority over her life again. She had been controlled, genuinely controlled, by a domineering church, and her deconstruction was in part a healthy escape from that control. But it did not stop at escaping the control. It kept going until it had removed anything at all that might make a claim on her, until the highest principle was that nothing could tell her what to do, and a faith that asks nothing of you is not a faith, it is a hobby. She did not tear down an idol and rebuild on rock. She tore down

the idol and then tore down the possibility of a foundation, because a foundation, too, is a thing that holds you in place, and she had come to experience being held in place as the enemy. I grieve for her. I understand exactly how she got there. And I cannot pretend she found something load-bearing, because she found a field, and a field is not a home.

*The tell is not the questions. The tell is whether the conclusion arrives carrying grief or carrying relief.*

So the line between the two kinds of tearing down is not visible in the tools or the questions or even in which beliefs survive. It is visible only in the orientation of the heart, and the heart's orientation shows itself slowly, over years, in the direction a person is actually walking underneath all the intellectual traffic. Are you tearing down in order to find, or in order to be free of the finding. Are you checking the beam because you love the house or because you want an excuse to leave it. Are you staying in the dark, waiting, or have you decided the dark means no one is there and walked out. You will not always know which one you are, and that is fine, because the two kinds are not sealed categories and a person can pass from one to the other in either direction. But you can ask yourself the question, honestly, in the quiet, and the question is this. If it turned out to be true, all of it, the crucified God and the empty tomb and the love stronger than death, would you be glad, or would you be disappointed. Sit with your honest answer. It will tell you which tearing down you are doing, and everything else in this book depends on knowing.

## Chapter Four: The Harm Was Real

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I am going to spend this chapter on the wound the church least wants to talk about, which is the wound the church itself inflicted, and I am going to ask the settled believers reading this to stay in the room even when it hurts, because you cannot understand why people are leaving until you are willing to look at what was done to them by the people who stayed. This is not the chapter where I explain away the harm. This is the chapter where I name it and refuse to explain it away, because the first thing a wounded person needs is not an argument. It is to be believed.

The harm was real. I have to say it plainly before I say anything else, because the church's instinct, my instinct, when confronted with harm done in God's name, is to rush to context, to explain, to say that most churches are not like that, to protect the institution. That instinct is exactly the instinct that made the harm possible in the first place. When a person tells you they were wounded by the church and your first move is to defend the church, you have just re-enacted the wound. You have told them, again, that the institution matters more than their pain. The leader who asked the woman in Chapter One what she was wearing was defending the institution. He was protecting the church's comfort at the cost of her body, and he did it in the name of God, and if you rush to explain that away you are standing exactly where he stood.

Let me be specific about the kinds of harm, because vagueness lets everyone off the hook. There is the sexual abuse, covered up, again and again, in denomination after denomination, in



churches of every size and style, a pattern so consistent across so many traditions that it can no longer be dismissed as a few bad men. There is the harm done to bodies and to spirits by a purity culture that taught children their desires were filthy and their worth was located between their legs, that told girls they were responsible for the thoughts of men and told boys that a glimpse of skin could destroy them, and that produced a generation who could not, on their wedding night, undo in an evening what had been done to them for a decade. There is the spiritual abuse of the domineering pastor, the one who taught that questioning him was questioning God, who used the fear of hell as a leash and the promise of belonging as a bribe. There is the harm done to whole categories of people told they were an abomination before they were old enough to know what the word meant. The harm was real. I am not going to soften it.

And I have to implicate the thing I love, which is the hardest sentence in this chapter. The church did this. Not a few outsiders wearing the church as a costume, though there were some of those. The church, the real church, the one with the missions budget and the youth group and the pastor who did not steal, did this, through its structures and its silences and its instinct to protect itself. I am a pastor. I am inside the thing I am indicting. I have been in the rooms where a report of harm was received and the first question asked was not how do we help the wounded person but how do we protect the church from scandal, and I have not always been the one who objected. I have participated in the culture that produced these wounds, by preaching a certainty that left no room for questions, by treating the institution's reputation as a thing to be guarded, by being slow, so slow, to believe the people who came to me with their pain because believing them would have cost me something. I did this. We did this. I will not point at the harm from a safe

distance, because there is no safe distance. I am standing in it.

Now here is what I have to say to the person who left because of this harm, and I want to say it carefully, because it would be obscene to rush from acknowledging the wound to defending God, as though the wound were a debating point. So let me be slow. If you left the church because the church hurt you, I do not think you made a mistake. I want to say that clearly. Leaving a place that is harming you is not a sin. It is often the sanest and most self-respecting thing a wounded person can do, and the God I believe in does not require you to stay in a burning building to prove your faith. The people who tell you that leaving the church is leaving God have made the same error the abusers made. They have fused the institution with God so completely that they cannot imagine God outside the walls that hurt you. But God was never contained by those walls. God, if the story is true, is the one who was Himself thrown out of the institution of His day, tried by its leaders, executed with its approval. The crucified God is not on the side of the institution that harmed you. He was harmed by an institution too.

That distinction is the whole game, and I want to slow down on it, because it is where faith survives the harm or does not. The harm was done by people and institutions claiming to represent God. The question that determines everything is whether they represented Him accurately. And the answer, when you actually look at Christ, is that they did not. The man who asked the woman what she was wearing was not doing what Jesus did. Jesus, in the eighth chapter of John, stood between a woman and the men who wanted to stone her and turned the accusation back on the accusers. Every single time the institution of His day used God to crush a vulnerable person, Jesus took the side of the crushed. So when the church crushed you in God's name, it was

not showing you God. It was showing you the exact thing God came to overturn. The harm was real, and the harm was a betrayal of the very One it was done in the name of, and those two facts do not cancel. They compound. The tragedy is not only that you were hurt. It is that you were hurt by people invoking the name of the one who would have defended you.

I know this can sound like a dodge, the classic move where the believer says that the bad Christians were not real Christians, and I want to be honest that the move can be a dodge, a way of never letting any actual church be responsible for anything. So let me not use it as a dodge. The church that hurt you was a real church. Those were real Christians, baptized, sincere, often convinced they were doing right. I am not going to play the game of defining them out of the faith to protect the faith's reputation. They were us. The abuse and the cover-up and the cruelty came from inside the house, from people who prayed and read their Bibles and meant it. That is more disturbing than the dodge, and I would rather be disturbed and honest than comforted and lying. The faith has to be able to account for the fact that real Christians did real harm, and it can, but only if it stops pretending that being a Christian makes a person safe. It does not. The gospel is not a character reference. It is a rescue, and rescued people remain capable of terrible things, which is exactly why the rescue was necessary.

*The people who hurt you in God's name were showing you the thing God came to overturn, not the God who came to overturn it.*

So where does this leave the harmed person who is trying to decide whether to keep any of it. It leaves you, I hope, with a distinction you can actually use. You do not have to choose

between pretending the harm was not real and concluding that God is not real. Those are not the only two doors. There is a third, and it is the hardest and the truest. The harm was real, and it was a betrayal of God, and the God who was betrayed by it is the same God who was Himself betrayed, tried, and killed by religious institutions, which means He is not your abuser's ally. He is, if anything, the first member of the club of those wounded by the church. You are not far from Him because the church hurt you. You may, in a terrible way you never wanted, be closer to Him than the people who hurt you ever were, because you know from the inside what it is to be crushed by the machinery of religion, and so did He. I cannot give the harm a reason. I will not try. But I can tell you where God was when it happened. He was not standing with the man asking what you were wearing. He was standing with you, having been asked the same kind of question by the same kind of man, on His way to a cross the institution built.

# Chapter Five: The Hypocrisy You Were Not Imagining

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There is a particular kind of pain that comes from watching the people who taught you about holiness turn out to be unholy, and it is not the pain of intellectual doubt, though it often disguises itself as that. It is the pain of betrayal, and betrayal is a wound to the trust, not to the reason. I want to spend this chapter on it because so many people who think they have an argument against God actually have a grief against a hypocrite, and until they can tell those two apart they will keep trying to solve a broken heart with a syllogism, and it will not work, because you cannot think your way out of a wound that was inflicted on your ability to trust.

You were not imagining it. That is the first thing. The church has a long habit of gaslighting the people who noticed its hypocrisy, telling them they were being judgmental, telling them to focus on their own sin, telling them that pointing out the leader's cruelty was itself a kind of pride. And there is a version of that correction that is true, because we are all hypocrites in some measure and the person who leaves the church over other people's hypocrisy has usually not reckoned with their own. But there is a version of that correction that is a weapon, used to silence the person who saw clearly that the man preaching about the sanctity of marriage was destroying his own, that the woman teaching about generosity was cruel to the poor, that the community that talked constantly about love was a machine for producing exclusion. You saw that. It was real. Do not let anyone tell you that seeing it was your sin.

I want to distinguish two things that get fused, because the fusion is where faith dies unnecessarily. There is the hypocrisy of individual Christians, which proves nothing about whether Christianity is true, and there is the hypocrisy of the system, which proves something about whether the system is healthy. The first one is often used as an argument and it is a bad argument. That a Christian failed to live up to Christ does not tell you Christ is false any more than a cowardly soldier tells you the cause was unjust. Every worthy standard produces people who fail to meet it, and the failure is evidence of the height of the standard, not the falseness of it. If the church were full of people who perfectly embodied its teaching you would rightly suspect the teaching demanded nothing. So the bare fact of hypocrites in the church is not the intellectual problem it is often taken to be, and the sophomore who thinks he has refuted Christianity by pointing out that Christians sin has refuted nothing but a strawman that never existed, a church of the already-perfect that the faith never claimed to be.

But I said there were two things, and the second one is the real one, and the church would rather you stayed focused on the first. The second is systemic hypocrisy, the kind that is not a matter of individuals failing to meet a standard but of the institution quietly abandoning the standard while continuing to preach it. That is different, and it is worse, and it is a legitimate reason to distrust a particular church even if it is not a reason to disbelieve God. When a church preaches that the last shall be first and then arranges all its honor and access around wealth and power, that is not individual hypocrisy. That is the system lying about what it values. When a church preaches truth-telling and then covers up its own scandals, that is not a few weak members. That is the institution revealing that its self-protection outranks its stated god. You were right to notice that. You were right to distrust it.

And the tragedy is that the church, by fusing itself with God, taught you that distrusting the lying institution meant distrusting God, when in fact the God the institution claimed to serve is the fiercest enemy of exactly that kind of lie.

Let me implicate myself again, because a chapter on hypocrisy written by a pastor who exempts himself is its own small hypocrisy. I have preached beyond my life. I have stood in a pulpit and called people to a forgiveness I was, at that moment, withholding from someone in my own family. I have talked about generosity while gripping my own comfort with both hands. I have warned against pride from a platform that fed my pride daily. There is no pastor honest enough to write this chapter who has not done this, and the ones who claim they have not are proving the point in the act of denying it. So when you tell me the church is full of hypocrites, I do not argue. I raise my hand. I am one of them. The question is not whether the church contains hypocrites, because it does, top to bottom, pulpit included. The question is what you conclude from that, and I want to steer you away from the conclusion that feels obvious and toward the one that is true.

The obvious conclusion is that if the teachers are hypocrites the teaching is false. But watch what that conclusion actually assumes. It assumes that a truth is only true if the people who carry it live up to it, and that is not how truth works in any other domain of life. The doctor who smokes has not disproven that smoking kills. The financial advisor who is bad with his own money has not made compound interest a myth. The mother who tells her child not to lie and then lies has not made honesty a fiction. In every other area we understand that a truth can be carried by people who fail it, and that their failure is a fact about them, not about the truth. Only with faith do we make the

strange move of concluding that the messenger's failure discredits the message. And I think we make that move because with faith the failure hurts more, because we trusted more, because we gave these people our childhood and our tithe and our obedience, and when they turned out to be frauds the betrayal was so total that it felt like the whole thing must be a fraud. That is the grief talking, and the grief is legitimate, but grief is not an argument.

*Hypocrisy in the pulpit is a fact about the man, not a verdict on the message he betrayed.*

Here is the harder pastoral word, and I save it for the end because it can only be heard after all the above. At some point, if you are going to have any faith at all on the far side of this, you will have to make a decision about whether you will let the hypocrites own Christ. Because that is what is at stake. If you conclude that the frauds who taught you have the final word on what Christianity is, then you have granted them a power over you that outlasts your leaving. You have let them define the thing forever, so that even in your rejection of it you are still living inside their version of it, still letting the worst representatives be the representatives. The alternative is harder and more freeing. You can decide that the hypocrites do not get to own Christ, that their betrayal of Him does not make Him theirs, that you are allowed to go looking for the real thing behind the frauds who claimed to speak for it. Most people who leave over hypocrisy never do this. They let the hypocrites keep Christ, as a final insult, and walk away leaving Him in the hands of the very people who abused Him. I am asking you to consider taking Him back from them instead. They do not deserve to be the last word on who He is. Neither do I. Go find out for yourself, behind all of us who failed Him.



## Chapter Six: When the Book Itself Is the Problem

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Now we come to the questions that wear the respectable clothing, the ones about the book itself, and I am not going to dodge them, because dodging them is how the church trained a generation of smart people to assume there were no honest answers. I am going to take the intellectual problems seriously as intellectual problems, which means I am not going to solve them with a feeling. But I also want to name, before we start, that the intellectual questions are frequently the socially acceptable version of a wound, the way the woman in Chapter One led with the councils and the canon before she could speak the real thing. So hold both. The questions are real and deserve real answers. And they are often not the whole story of why a person is leaving, and pretending they are can be its own way of not looking at the wound underneath.

Here is the problem stated at full strength, and I will not weaken it to make it easier to answer. You were probably taught that the Bible was, in some sense, dropped from heaven, a single unified book, without error, saying one consistent thing, the very words of God. And then, somewhere, you learned that it is not that. You learned that it was written across a thousand years by dozens of authors in three languages, that the books were argued over and selected by councils of fallible men, that there are manuscripts that disagree with each other, that the Gospels tell the same stories differently and sometimes contradict on details, that the Old Testament contains laws about slavery and genocide and the treatment of women that no decent person could obey today. And

when you learned all that, the model you had been given, the dropped-from-heaven model, could not hold it, and it broke. And you concluded, reasonably, that if the book is not what you were told it was, then maybe none of it is what you were told.

I want to say something that will surprise the people who think a pastor's job is to defend the book at all costs. The dropped-from-heaven model deserved to break. It was never the church's actual doctrine of Scripture, not for most of the church's history, not for most of the church's best thinkers. It was a relatively recent, relatively local invention, a defensive crouch adopted in reaction to modern skepticism, and it made a promise about the Bible that the Bible never makes about itself. The Bible does not claim to be a science textbook. It does not claim to be a single-authored, internally uniform document that fell whole from the sky. That is a claim some Christians made on its behalf in the last century or two, and it is a fragile claim, and it breaks the first time you actually read the thing closely, which is why so many of the people who leave over the Bible are people who finally read it closely. They were set up. They were handed a model of the book that the book itself refutes, and then when they read the book and it refuted the model, they thought it had refuted God.

Peter Enns, in his book *The Bible Tells Me So*, published in twenty-fourteen, spent an entire volume on this, arguing that the problem is not the Bible but the expectations we bring to it, expectations it never asked us to have. When we demand that the Bible be a flawless, timeless rulebook, we are demanding something it never claimed to be, and then blaming it for not being the thing we invented. What if, Enns asks, the Bible is exactly what it looks like, an ancient, complicated, human, God-breathed record of a people wrestling with God across centuries, arguing with each other in its own pages, growing and changing

in its understanding, sometimes getting things wrong and being corrected later in its own story. That is not a lesser Bible. It is the actual Bible, the one in your hands, and it is far more interesting and far more durable than the plastic idol of inerrancy that shatters the moment a bright fourteen-year-old notices that the two accounts of Judas's death do not match.

Let me take the hardest specific case head-on, because the general point means nothing if I flinch at the particulars. The genocide passages. The book of Joshua has God commanding the slaughter of entire cities, including the children. I am not going to tell you that is fine. It is not fine. If a voice told you today to do what those passages describe, you would rightly conclude the voice was demonic, and your moral horror at those texts is not a failure of faith. It is the very moral formation the rest of the Bible gave you, turning back on the Bible's own darkest pages. So what do we do. One option, the one you were probably given, is to defend it, to explain that the Canaanites were very wicked, to make the horror smaller. I cannot do that and keep my soul. The other option, the one the honest tradition has always held open, is to read the whole book as a record of a people's growing understanding of God, in which the early portraits of a tribal war-god who commands slaughter are not God's final word about Himself but an early and partial and culturally bound picture, one that the same Scripture will later overturn when a prophet says God desires mercy and not sacrifice, and finally shatter completely when God shows up in the flesh and dies rather than kill.

This is the move the church is most afraid of, because it sounds like admitting the Bible has error in it, and the dropped-from-heaven model cannot survive that admission. But watch what you gain when you let that model die. You get a Bible that makes

sense as what it manifestly is, an unfolding story in which the understanding of God deepens and corrects itself, culminating in Christ, who is the lens through which all the earlier pictures must be read. Jesus Himself does this. Again and again in the Sermon on the Mount He says, you have heard that it was said, and then, but I say to you, and He is correcting the earlier Scripture, deepening it, sometimes reversing it. If Jesus can hold the Old Testament that way, treating it as true and yet not final, as authoritative and yet superseded in His own person, then the model that cannot bear a single contradiction was never His model. He read His own Bible the way the inerrantists forbid you to read yours.

*The Bible you were handed shattered because it was an idol. The Bible that was actually there survives the shattering.*

I am aware that some of you will find this less comforting than I intend it, because you wanted the dropped-from-heaven Bible and I am telling you it is gone. I understand. There is a real loss here, the loss of a certain kind of certainty, the comfort of a rulebook that settles every question with a verse. That comfort is genuinely gone, and I will not pretend it is not. But I want you to consider what you are trading it for. You are trading a fragile idol that breaks the moment you read it honestly for a living, ancient, difficult text that can bear the full weight of your honesty, that invites the argument, that contains its own dissent, that grows the way you grow. That is not a downgrade. That is the difference between a photograph of a fire and a fire. The photograph is safer and it cannot warm you. The fire is dangerous and it is the only thing in the room that is actually alive. The book you were taught to defend was a photograph. The book that is actually there will burn your hands, and it is the only one worth keeping.

## Chapter Seven: The God Who Seemed Cruel

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I put off this chapter as long as I could, because it is the one closest to my own faith's collapse, and writing it means going back into the rooms where my picture of God died. But it is the center of the whole thing for many of you, so I will go back. The question is not intellectual, though it can be dressed that way. The question is a wound in the trust. You were told God is love, and then you met a God, in the pages of Scripture or in the events of your own life, who did not act like love, and the gap between the God you were promised and the God you encountered opened under your feet, and you fell through it. That is not a debate you lost. That is a betrayal you suffered, and it deserves to be treated as one.

Let me name the God who seemed cruel, in both His forms, because there are two and they wound differently. There is the cruel God of the text, the one who hardens Pharaoh's heart and then punishes him for it, who drowns the world, who commands the slaughter I wrote about in the last chapter, who seems, in certain passages, capricious and violent and jealous in the small human way. And there is the cruel God of experience, which is worse, because it is yours. This is the God who did not come when you begged, who let the diagnosis be what you feared, who stood by while the thing you prayed against happened anyway, who was silent in the exact hour you needed Him to speak. The God of the text you could perhaps argue about. The God of your experience you cannot argue about, because He did not show up, and no amount of theology fills the chair He left empty.

I will not solve the second one with the first one, and I want to be clear about that, because the church's great error here is to answer the wound of God's silence with an explanation of the text, as though a person weeping over an empty chair needed a lecture on hermeneutics. If you prayed for your child and your child died, I have no verse for you. I want to say that with all the force I have. I have sat with too many people in that exact place to hand them a reason, and every pastor who hands out reasons in that room should have his ordination revoked, because the reasons are not comfort, they are the pastor's own fear of silence, dressed as help. The book of Job spends thirty-five chapters letting Job's friends explain his suffering, giving reason after reasonable reason, and then God shows up and says the friends were wrong, all of them, the whole enterprise of explaining was an offense. If you have been given reasons for your suffering by well-meaning Christians, know that the book of Job is on your side against them. God does not explain Himself to Job. He does something stranger. He shows up.

But let me stay with the cruel God of the text for a while, because there is real work to do there and it feeds back into the other. When you read a passage where God seems cruel, you are standing at a fork, and the church usually pretends only one path exists. The first path is to defend the cruelty, to say that God's ways are higher than ours and who are you to question, that what looks like cruelty is actually a justice too deep for you to see. I have walked that path and I have watched it destroy people, because it requires you to call cruelty good, to override the very conscience that God supposedly gave you, and a faith that requires you to betray your conscience to keep it is not asking for faith, it is asking for the death of your soul. The second path, the one I take, is to say that the cruel-seeming portrait is a real part of an unfolding story in which the picture of God is being

purified over time, and that the final and definitive picture is not the war-god of Joshua but the crucified God of Golgotha, and that when the two conflict, the cross wins.

The cross wins. I want to make that the load-bearing sentence of this chapter, because it is the answer to the cruel God that does not require you to call cruelty good. If Jesus is the fullest revelation of who God is, and the whole New Testament insists that He is, the exact image of the invisible God, the one who says if you have seen me you have seen the Father, then every prior picture of God has to be read in His light and corrected where it conflicts. And what does the definitive picture show. It shows a God who, when He finally arrives in person, does not slaughter His enemies but is slaughtered by them. It shows a God who does not command the death of children but weeps at the death of His friend. It shows a God whose power looks like a man refusing to come down from a cross He could have escaped, absorbing the cruelty of the world into His own body rather than inflicting it. That is the center. The cruel passages are real, and they are early, and they are not the center, and the church committed a catastrophe when it taught you to read the fringe as though it outranked the center.

Walter Brueggemann, the great scholar of the Old Testament, spent his career insisting that the Bible does not present a single flat portrait of God but a long, contested argument, a text in which Israel praises God and also accuses God, trusts God and also files a lawsuit against God, and that the accusation and the lawsuit are not failures of faith but part of the faith, canonized, kept, given to us on purpose. The Psalms of lament, which we will spend a whole chapter on, are Israel telling God to His face that He seems absent and unjust, and God kept those prayers in the book. Think about what that means. The complaint against

the cruel-seeming God is inside the Bible. The Bible anticipated your objection and gave you the language for it. You are not the first person to look at God and think this looks like cruelty. The people who wrote the Bible thought it too, and instead of editing out the thought, they enshrined it, which tells you something about the kind of God this is, a God who would rather have your honest accusation than your dishonest praise.

*When the war-god of the early pages and the crucified God of Golgotha conflict, the cross wins. It was always meant to win.*

So what do you do with the God who seemed cruel to you personally, the one who left the chair empty. I told you I would not solve it, and I will not, but I can tell you what I found on the far side of my own collapse, when the manageable God died and I thought God had died with Him. What I found was that the God who was left, once the manageable one was gone, was not the cruel God I feared and not the safe God I had lost. He was the crucified God, the one who does not stand outside my suffering explaining it but enters it and suffers it Himself. That God I could not accuse of cruelty from a safe distance, because He was not at a safe distance. He was in the room I had thought was empty, not as an explanation, but as a fellow sufferer, which is a stranger and harder and truer kind of presence than the answer I had wanted. I wanted a God who would explain the empty chair. I got a God who came and sat in it with me. It took me years to understand that the second is more than the first, that a companion in the dark is worth more than a floodlight, that Barbara Brown Taylor was right, there is a way of knowing God that only opens after the lights go out. The cruel God was a picture. The crucified God was in the room. I had to lose the first to find the second, and I would not go back.



# Chapter Eight: The Hell You Were Threatened With

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Few doctrines have driven more people out of the faith than the doctrine of hell, and few have been handled with less honesty by the people teaching it, so let me try to handle it honestly, which means neither defending the version that damaged you nor pretending the whole matter can be waved away. Hell is in the book. Jesus talked about it. I am not going to make it disappear to comfort you, because a faith built on making the hard things disappear is exactly the fragile thing this book is trying to help you leave behind. But I am going to insist that the version of hell that was used as a weapon against you is very likely not the thing the book is actually talking about, and that distinguishing the two is a large part of the work.

Let me name the hell you were threatened with, because it needs to be named before it can be examined. It was a place of conscious, physical, unending torture, to which a loving God consigned the vast majority of the human race, including people who had simply never heard the right name or been born in the right place, for the crime of finite unbelief across a finite life, punished with infinite suffering forever. And it was used as a leash. It was held over you as a child to keep you in line, deployed at the end of every emotional altar call, made vivid with descriptions of flames and screaming, so that you accepted Christ not out of love but out of terror, the way a hostage accepts the terms of a captor. If that is the hell you knew, then your revulsion at it is not a sign you have gone soft on sin. It is a sign that the moral sense God gave you is recoiling from a portrait of

God that is, in fact, a monstrous distortion, and your recoil is more faithful than the doctrine you are recoiling from.

Here is what I have come to believe after years of study and years of watching this doctrine do its damage, and I offer it not as the final word but as an honest one. The lurid, eternal-conscious-torture-chamber version of hell owes at least as much to Dante and to medieval imagination and to the fears of frightened preachers as it does to the actual words of Jesus, and when you go back to those words you find something both less cartoonish and more serious. The words translated as hell in the Gospels are mostly Gehenna, which was a real place, a valley outside Jerusalem, a garbage dump where fires burned, a location with a specific horrifying history that Jesus's hearers knew. When Jesus warned about Gehenna He was using a concrete image His audience understood, and He was most often warning not random pagans in far countries but the religious insiders, the ones sure they were safe, that their hardness of heart was leading them toward a real ruin. The doctrine was a warning to the smug, not a threat against the vulnerable, and the church inverted it, turning a warning to the powerful into a leash for the frightened.

I want to hold open several possibilities here rather than slam one shut, because honesty requires it and because the tradition itself has held several. Sincere, orthodox Christians across the centuries have understood the final fate of the lost in more than one way. Some have held the traditional view of conscious eternal separation, and taken pains to strip it of the cartoon flames and locate the horror in the reality of a soul that has finally and freely refused love forever. Some have held that the lost are not tortured forever but finally cease to be, that the wages of sin is death and death means death, that eternal in those passages describes the finality of the outcome rather than the

endless duration of the suffering. Some have held, tentatively and with trembling, a hope that God's love will in the end reach further than we dare to say, though the honest ones hold it as hope and not as certainty, because presumption is its own error. I am not going to tell you which of these is correct, partly because I am genuinely unsure, and partly because your capacity to have any faith at all may depend first on your realizing that the cartoon you were threatened with is not the only option the faith has ever offered.

Let me implicate myself, because I have preached hell badly. In my early years I used it the way it was used on me, as the closer, the emotional lever, the thing that got people down the aisle. I described the flames. I made children afraid. I told people, in effect, that God had a torture chamber and only Jesus stood between them and it, and I called this evangelism. I did not consider that I was training people to see God as a cosmic abuser from whom Jesus was rescuing them, which is a heresy, because it splits the Father from the Son and makes the Father the monster and the Son the hero, when the whole point of the gospel is that the Father and the Son are one and the rescue is the Father's own idea and the Father's own act. I taught a generation to fear the Father and love the Son, which is not Christianity, and some of those people, when they grew up and could not sustain the fear, threw out the whole thing, and I helped build the exit they left through.

The deepest problem with the weaponized hell is what it does to the character of God, and this is where it connects to the last chapter. If God tortures the majority of His creatures forever for finite crimes, then God is worse than the worst human tyrant, because no human tyrant has the power to make suffering literally endless, and a God like that is not a God you can love,

only a God you can submit to out of terror. And a faith built on terror is not faith. It is hostage compliance. The people who left over hell often left because they finally could not reconcile the God of infinite torture with the God of the cross, and instead of resolving the contradiction by throwing out the cartoon, they resolved it by throwing out God, because no one had ever told them the cartoon was optional. No one had told them that the same Jesus who mentioned Gehenna also told a story about a shepherd who left ninety-nine sheep to find one, and searched until He found it, and I have never in my life heard that shepherd described as one who would then throw the found sheep into a fire.

*The hell that was used to frighten you into the faith was itself a reason to leave it, and no one told you it was optional.*

I will not end this chapter by resolving hell, because I cannot, and the ones who claim they can are usually selling something. What I will do is separate two questions that the weaponized version fused. The first question is whether there is a real and terrible possibility that a soul can finally and forever refuse the love it was made for, and to that I say yes, there is, and taking that seriously is part of taking freedom and love seriously, because a love you cannot refuse is not love. The second question is whether God is an eternal torturer who delights in the endless agony of the majority of His children, and to that I say no, that is a slander against the crucified God, a cartoon assembled from medieval fear and frightened preaching, and you were right to recoil from it. Keep the first. Throw out the second. And notice that you can do that, that the faith has room for you to do that, that your moral horror at the cartoon was not the beginning of your apostasy but the beginning of a truer picture of

God, if only someone had been there to tell you so. I am telling you so now. It is late, and I am sorry it is late, but I am telling you.

# Chapter Nine: The Science You Were Told to Fear

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I want to talk about the false war, the one that was manufactured and then handed to you as though it were the nature of reality, the war between science and faith. Many people who left the church left over this, and they left believing they were choosing knowledge over superstition, and I understand why, because the version of Christianity they were given had genuinely set itself against knowledge, had genuinely told them that to accept the age of the earth or the descent of species was to deny God, and so when the evidence became undeniable they concluded, honestly, that God must be denied. But they were sold a false choice by frightened people, and I want to take it apart, because the choice was never real, and a great many of the finest scientific minds in history were and are believers, which by itself should have told you the war was a local skirmish, not a cosmic law.

Let me be precise about what happened, because vagueness protects the people who did the damage. A particular strand of Christianity, quite recent and quite localized, made a wager that the truth of God depended on a literal reading of the first chapters of Genesis, on a young earth and a six-day creation and no shared ancestry between humans and other creatures. Having made that wager, it then had to fight every piece of evidence that contradicted it, and the evidence was enormous and it kept coming, from geology and biology and cosmology and genetics, and so the church found itself, generation after generation, on the losing side of one factual question after another, defending

positions that the evidence had already overrun. And the children raised inside that fight learned a lesson the church did not intend to teach. They learned that faith requires you to deny what is plainly true, and when they grew up and could no longer deny it, they threw out the faith along with the denial, because they had been taught the two were the same thing.

But they were never the same thing. This is the part the frightened church could not tell you, because it had bet everything on the literal reading and could not afford to admit the bet was foolish. The oldest and best tradition of Christian reading never required Genesis to be a science textbook. Augustine, writing in the fourth century, warned Christians not to make fools of themselves by insisting on literal readings of Scripture in matters where the evidence of the world said otherwise, because doing so brought the faith into disrepute and gave unbelievers a reason to dismiss the parts that actually mattered. That is Augustine, sixteen hundred years ago, warning against exactly the mistake that drove you out. The insistence that Genesis must be read as a scientific account is not the ancient faith. It is a modern reaction, born of fear, and it has done incalculable damage, and it was never necessary, because Genesis was never trying to tell you the mechanism or the timeline. It was telling you something the mechanism and the timeline can never tell you, which is that the world is not an accident, that it was made and called good, that you bear the image of the one who made it. Science can tell you how. It was never equipped to tell you why, or whether the whole thing means anything, and Genesis was answering the question science does not ask.

Consider what you actually gain and lose in the trade. When you accept the scientific account of the age and development of the

universe, what have you lost of the faith. You have lost a literal six days and a young earth, which the best of the tradition never required. What have you kept. You have kept every load-bearing claim, that the world is created and not self-existent, that it is good, that human beings are more than accidents, that there is a purpose beneath the process. None of those claims is touched by the fossil record or the expansion of the universe or the mapping of the genome. The science tells you the how of a thing whose why remains exactly as open as it ever was, and in fact the deeper science goes, the more astonishing the why becomes, the more the fine-tuning of the constants and the strange fact that the universe is comprehensible at all press the question that science by its nature cannot answer. The war was never between science and faith. It was between science and one nervous, recent, over-literal reading of a few chapters, and you were told the skirmish was the whole war so that you would not notice how small the actual conflict was.

I have to be careful here not to overclaim, because the honest position cuts against triumphalism on my own side too. I am not going to tell you that science proves God, because it does not, and the Christians who claim it does are making the mirror image of the atheist's error, treating a question science cannot settle as though science settles it in their favor. What I am telling you is narrower and firmer. Science does not disprove God, and it cannot, because the question of whether there is a purpose and a purposer behind the physical process is not a scientific question, and no experiment will ever answer it. The universe's age and mechanism are questions for science, and science has answered them, and the answers are magnificent and the church should have celebrated them instead of fighting them. Whether the whole magnificent process means anything, whether there is Someone whose intention it expresses, is a question in a different



category, and on that question the laboratory is silent, not because the answer is no, but because the instrument does not measure that.

Let me name a personal cost, because I lived on the other side of this line. As an atheist I believed, as many do, that science had settled the God question in the negative, that a person who understood evolution and cosmology simply could not seriously believe. It was one of the walls I hid behind, and it was a false wall, and part of what dismantled my unbelief was realizing that the wall was not made of science at all but of a philosophy I had smuggled in alongside the science and mistaken for science. The philosophy said that the physical is all there is, that if you can explain the mechanism you have explained the thing away, that a described process needs no author. But that philosophy is not a finding of science. It is an assumption brought to science, and once I saw it as an assumption rather than a discovery, the wall stopped being a wall. I could accept every fact the scientists had established and the God question stood open before me, exactly as open as it had ever been, and I had to answer it on other grounds, because the ground I thought had settled it had never actually addressed it.

*The war between science and faith was a local skirmish sold to you as a cosmic law, so you would not notice how small it really was.*

So if you left over science, I want to offer you the possibility that you left a fight you never needed to be in. You do not have to choose between the age of the universe and the meaning of it, between the mechanism and the maker, between what the telescope shows and what the soul suspects. The frightened church set those against each other, and you were right to side

with the evidence, but you were misled into thinking that siding with the evidence meant leaving God, when in truth the evidence and God were never on opposite sides. They were answering different questions, and only fear made them enemies. You can keep everything the microscope and the telescope have shown you. You lose nothing that matters by keeping it. And on the far side of the false war, the real question is still there, undisturbed by any finding, waiting where it has always waited, which is not in the laboratory but in the place where you lie awake and wonder whether all of this stunning, ancient, comprehensible immensity is going somewhere, or nowhere, and whether it was meant.

# Chapter Ten: The Exclusivity That Troubled You

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Here is a question that troubles thoughtful people more than the church admits, and troubles the kindest people most of all, because it is a question that arises precisely from love. If Christianity is true, what about everyone else. What about the sincere Muslim, the devout Hindu, the good atheist, your grandmother who never darkened a church door and was the most generous person you knew. What about the billions who lived and died having never heard the name, or having heard it only from people who gave them no reason to want it. The church often taught you a hard and simple answer, that they are all lost, all of them, every last soul outside the specific transaction you were taught, and the sheer scale of that consignment, the coldness of it, the way it seemed to make an accident of birthplace into an eternal sentence, was for many of you the thing you finally could not swallow. And I want to say, again, that your inability to swallow it was not a defect of faith. It was your love working correctly.

Let me name the hard version and not soften it, because softening it is a way of not being honest. The hard version says that a person's eternal destiny is determined by whether they made a specific profession of a specific faith in a specific name, and that all who did not, regardless of what they knew or had access to or how they lived, are eternally lost. And the trouble with the hard version is not only that it seems cruel, though it does, but that it seems to make salvation a matter of information and luck, a cosmic lottery in which the winning ticket is having

been born in the right place to the right people who told you the right story. It makes God the author of a system in which the deciding factor is not the state of a person's heart toward the good but the accident of their exposure to a piece of news. And that offends something the Bible itself teaches, that God is not a respecter of persons, that He judges the heart, that He is just. The hard version, taken to its logical end, makes God unjust, and you noticed, and your noticing was not rebellion. It was you taking God's justice more seriously than the people who taught you the hard version did.

Now let me do the harder thing, which is to hold onto what is true in the exclusivity while throwing out what is false. Because there is something true in it, and the temptation, once you have seen the cruelty of the hard version, is to swing to the opposite error and say that all roads lead to the same place, that it makes no difference what anyone believes, that every religion is a different path up the same mountain. That is a comforting idea and it is also, if you look at it closely, its own kind of arrogance and its own kind of condescension, because it can only be held by someone standing above all the religions and quietly overruling what each of them actually claims about itself, telling the Muslim and the Christian and the Buddhist that their real meaning is something none of them believe, a meaning visible only to the enlightened observer who has transcended them all. The all-roads view sounds humble and is secretly the least humble position in the room, because it alone claims to see the whole mountain while everyone else sees only their path.

So what is the truth in Christian exclusivity, once we have stripped the cruelty. The truth is a claim not about the fate of individuals but about the person of Christ. The claim is that Jesus is not one teacher among many but the decisive act of God in

history, the point where God Himself entered the world and did something that changed the terms of everything, and that whatever salvation any person receives, wherever and whenever they lived, is received through what He did, whether or not they knew His name when they received it. That is a very different claim from the lottery. It says that Christ is the one door, yes, but it does not say that the only people who go through the door are the ones who could see the sign over it. The New Testament itself is more generous and more mysterious on this than the hard version allows. It speaks of people who never had the law being judged by the law written on their hearts. It shows Jesus astonished by the faith of outsiders. It insists that the ground of salvation is His work, and it is remarkably reticent about drawing the precise boundary of who benefits from that work, a reticence the hard version replaces with a confidence the Bible never authorized.

C.S. Lewis, in the final book of his Narnia stories, published in nineteen fifty-six, gave an image that got him accused of heresy and that I have come to think is closer to the truth than his accusers. A man who had served a false god his whole life, sincerely, seeking the good under the wrong name, is welcomed by the true God, who tells him that the good he sought and served was in fact being received by the true God all along, because no service of genuine goodness is ever really offered to the false. I am not going to build a doctrine on a children's story, but I raise it because it points at something the hard version cannot see, that the distinction between those who are saved and those who are lost may run not along the visible line of religious profession but along a deeper line, the line of the heart's true orientation toward or away from the good, the true, the self-giving love that is God's own nature, a line that God alone can see and that does not map neatly onto the boundaries of the

visible church.

I want to keep my own honesty here and not sell you a universalism I do not hold, because I have promised not to flatter easy exits. I do not know the fate of the sincere Muslim or the good atheist or your generous grandmother, and I distrust anyone who claims to know, in either direction, the one who consigns them all confidently to hell and the one who waves them all confidently into heaven. Both know more than a human being can know. What I hold is narrower and, I think, more faithful. Christ is the door, and the door is wider than the sign over it, and the Judge is more just and more merciful than the frightened preachers who claimed to speak for Him, and I can leave the fate of the ones I love in the hands of a God who was willing to die for them rather than in the hands of a doctrine that consigns them before He has spoken. That is not the same as saying it does not matter. It matters infinitely. It is saying that the God who will draw the line is the God who bled, and I trust His justice more than I trust the certainty of the people who taught me to fear it.

*The all-roads view is the most arrogant position in the room, and the hard version makes God unjust. There is a third thing, and it bleeds.*

So if the exclusivity troubled you, if you could not reconcile the God of love with the God who damns the majority for the accident of their birth, I want to tell you that your trouble was righteous, that you were defending God's justice against the people who compromised it, and that the faith has more room than they let you see. You do not have to choose between a cruel exclusivism that makes an idol of the transaction and a flabby relativism that empties Christ of all significance. There is a harder and truer place to stand, where Christ is genuinely the

decisive act of God for the whole world, and where the reach of that act is wider and more mysterious than any human being is entitled to map, and where the drawing of every final line is left, as it should be, to the only one just enough and merciful enough to draw it. That God I can worship. The God of the lottery I could not, and neither, it turns out, could you, and your refusal was the beginning of a truer worship, not the end of worship altogether.

# Chapter Eleven: Doubt Is Not the Opposite of Faith

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I need to correct something that was done to you, a lie so deep in the church's water that most of the people who repeat it do not know they are lying. You were taught that doubt is the opposite of faith, that a believer who doubts is a believer who is failing, that the presence of the question is the absence of the trust. And so, when the doubts came, as they come to everyone eventually, you experienced them not as an ordinary part of a thinking person's spiritual life but as a betrayal, a symptom of something rotting, and you either hid them or fled from them, because you had been given no third option. You did not know you were allowed to doubt and keep believing at the same time. No one told you that the two could share a body. So I am going to tell you now, plainly, and then spend the chapter proving it. Doubt is not the opposite of faith. The opposite of faith is certainty, and the opposite of faith is indifference, but doubt is something else entirely. Doubt is faith staying in the room with its hardest questions instead of leaving.

Start with the word. Faith, in the New Testament, is not a synonym for certainty. It never was. The Greek word carries the sense of trust, of allegiance, of a leaning of the whole self toward something not fully seen. Certainty is a state of the intellect. Faith is a posture of the person, and the two are not the same, and you can have a great deal of one with very little of the other. Abraham, who the New Testament calls the father of faith, laughs at God's promise, argues with God, tries to engineer the promise himself when he doubts it will arrive, and God counts



him faithful anyway, not because he never doubted but because through all the doubting he kept leaning toward the God he could not fully believe. If faith required certainty, the Bible would have to disqualify half its heroes. Instead it keeps their doubts in the record, on purpose, so that you would know the club you are in when you doubt is not the club of the failures. It is the club of the patriarchs.

Consider the father in Mark, the one whose words open this book. His son is afflicted, and Jesus says all things are possible to the one who believes, and the father cries out the sentence that has become my favorite in all of Scripture. I believe, help my unbelief. Read what he is actually saying. He is saying that both things are true of him at once, the belief and the unbelief, that they are not sequential, first one then the other, but simultaneous, occupying the same heart in the same instant. And here is the thing the church needs to hear. Jesus does not correct him. Jesus does not say, come back when you have resolved the contradiction, come back when the unbelief is gone and only the belief remains. Jesus heals the boy. He acts on the man's mixed and honest faith, the faith that came holding its own doubt in its hand, and He honors it. If Jesus honored that, then the church that shames it has set itself against its own Lord.

I want to name the deep reason the church fears doubt, because naming it dissolves much of its power. The church fears doubt because the church has too often built its life on certainty rather than on trust, and a house built on certainty must treat every question as a threat to the foundation, because the foundation is certainty and questions erode certainty. But a house built on trust does not fear questions the same way, because trust does not depend on having every answer. I trust my wife. That trust does not require me to have certainty about every thought in her head

or every moment of her past. It is a leaning of my whole life toward her that survives the presence of things I do not know. If my trust in her collapsed the moment I encountered a question I could not answer about her, it was never trust. It was surveillance dressed as love. And a faith that collapses the moment it meets a question it cannot answer was never faith. It was certainty dressed as faith, and certainty is a brittle idol that shatters, while faith is a living thing that can hold a question the way a marriage holds a mystery.

Let me implicate myself, because I preached the lie. For years I ran a ministry that treated doubt as a problem to be fixed, that met the doubting person with apologetics, with arguments, with a determination to resolve their questions so they could get back to the certainty I mistook for faith. And I drove people away by doing it, because a person in real doubt does not primarily need their questions answered. They need to be told that the questions do not disqualify them, that they are still welcome, still held, still inside the community even while they are unsure, and the moment I met their doubt with an argument I communicated the opposite, that their belonging was conditional on the resolution of their uncertainty, that they could not be one of us until they were certain again. I turned the church into a place where you had to already have arrived in order to stay, and that is a fatal thing to do to a doubting person, because doubting people cannot promise to arrive, and so they left, and I called it their unbelief when it was my failure to make room.

The tradition, at its best, has always known better than my worst practice, and it is worth knowing that the great believers were great doubters. Mother Teresa's private letters, published after her death, revealed decades of spiritual darkness, a felt absence of God so total that she wondered whether He was there at all,

and she served Him faithfully the entire time, in the dark, without the felt certainty, and the church that reflexively shames doubt had to reckon with the fact that one of its saints was a lifelong doubter who never stopped being faithful. Barbara Brown Taylor, whom I have quoted before, gave up her pulpit in part because she could no longer sustain the performance of certainty the church demanded, and found, in the letting go, a truer and darker and more durable faith, a faith that could walk in the dark because it had stopped insisting on the lights. These are not the faith's failures. These are among its deepest examples, and every one of them would have been driven out of the average congregation for admitting what they carried.

*The opposite of faith is not doubt. The opposite of faith is certainty, which cannot bend, and so, when the wind comes, can only break.*

So here is what I want you to receive, if you receive nothing else from this chapter. Your doubt does not put you outside the faith. It may, in fact, be the most alive part of your faith, the part that is still engaged, still wrestling, still refusing to settle for a certainty it cannot honestly hold. The people who never doubt are not always the strongest believers. Sometimes they are simply the ones who have stopped thinking, who have traded a living trust for a dead certainty because certainty is easier to carry. Your doubt is the sign that your faith is still a real relationship with a real God and not a settled opinion about a distant idea, because you do not doubt an idea, you doubt a person you are actually dealing with. The father in Mark did not have an opinion about Jesus. He had a boy who needed healing and a heart that could not fully believe and a desperate honesty that brought both into the presence of Christ, and that honesty was counted as faith. Bring your doubt the same way. Do not leave it at the door,

because the door is where the church told you to leave it and the church was wrong. Bring it in. Set it down in front of Him. Say the true thing. I believe, help my unbelief. And then watch what He does with a faith honest enough to admit it is not sure. He does not turn it away. He never once turned it away.

# Chapter Twelve: The God Who Can Survive Your Questions

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There is a fear underneath all the questions, and I want to name it, because until it is named it runs the whole show from the shadows. The fear is that if you ask the real questions, the ones you have been holding back, God will not survive them. That somewhere in you there is a question so sharp, an objection so final, that to speak it fully would be to kill God, to reach the bottom of the faith and find that the bottom gives way. And so you have been protecting God, censoring yourself, holding the worst questions back, not out of reverence but out of terror, because you suspect that God is fragile, that He can only survive if you do not press too hard, that faith is a thin ice you must not stamp on. I want to take that fear apart, because it is based on a picture of God that is exactly backward, and the picture is the thing that has to die for your faith to live.

Here is the backward picture. God as a delicate structure, an argument that holds only if you do not examine it too closely, a belief that requires your protection, a house of cards that your hard questions could topple. If that is your God, then every serious question is a threat, and the spiritual life becomes an exercise in not-looking, in keeping your eyes carefully averted from the places where the structure might not hold, and this is exhausting, and it is also, though you may not have noticed, a kind of contempt for God, because it treats Him as something you must handle carefully lest He break. You cannot love a God you are protecting. You can only manage Him. And the constant low-grade labor of not-asking, of steering your mind away from

the cliffs, drains the life out of faith until what is left is a careful, anxious, brittle thing that calls itself belief but is really just a refusal to look.

Now here is the true picture, and it changes everything. God is not the fragile structure. God is the ground the structure stands on. Your beliefs about God are the structure, and those can and should be tested, and some of them will not hold, and that is fine, because they were never God, they were your beliefs about God, the scaffolding you built to think about Him. When a false belief about God collapses under a hard question, God has not collapsed. A wrong idea about God has collapsed, which is a service to God, not a threat to Him. You have been terrified that your questions would kill God, when your questions can only kill your idols, and killing your idols is the one thing that has ever cleared enough space for the real God to be seen. The fear had it exactly backward. The questions do not endanger God. They endanger the false gods that stand between you and Him, and He has never been threatened by their fall. He has been waiting for it.

Think about the God who is actually revealed in the Scriptures and ask whether He behaves like a fragile thing. He invites Job to bring his complaint, and when Job's friends defend God with pious lies, God rebukes the friends and vindicates the man who accused Him honestly. He gives His people the Psalms of lament, prayers of raw accusation, and preserves them in the sacred text for three thousand years, which is not the behavior of a God afraid of hard questions but of a God who wants them, who would rather have your fury than your fake peace. He lets Jacob wrestle Him all night and does not destroy him but blesses him and renames him, and the name means one who wrestles with God, and it becomes the name of the whole people, so that

the very identity of the faithful is bound up with wrestling. This is not a God who needs your protection. This is a God who has been inviting the fight for four thousand years, who counts the wrestlers among His favorites, who seems, if anything, more troubled by the ones who will not engage than by the ones who come at Him with everything they have.

Let me tell you what it was like to finally ask the questions I had been holding back, because I did hold them back, even as a pastor, especially as a pastor, because I had a professional stake in the structure not collapsing. For years there were things I would not let myself think all the way to the end, cliffs I steered my mind away from, because I was afraid that if I thought them fully my faith and my vocation and my whole life would go down together. And when my faith came apart in that office, one of the things that came apart was the not-asking, because there was no longer anything to protect. The structure had already fallen. And so, in the rubble, I finally asked the questions I had censored for a decade, asked them all the way to the bottom, with nothing left to lose. And here is what happened, and it is the reason I can write this book. God was at the bottom. Not my picture of God, which was already gone, but God, the ground under the fallen structure, still there, unthreatened, having survived every question I had been too afraid to ask, because He was never the thing my questions could destroy. My questions destroyed my idols and left Him standing, and I met Him, for the first time since my conversion, not as a structure I was maintaining but as a ground I was standing on, and the ground did not move.

I want to be careful, because this can sound like a promise that everyone who asks the hard questions will find God at the bottom, and I cannot promise that, because I do not control the

outcome and neither do you. Some people ask the questions all the way down and do not find God there, or do not find Him yet, or find only silence, and I am not going to paper over that with a guarantee, because a guarantee would be a lie and this book does not deal in lies. What I can tell you is narrower. Whatever is at the bottom of your honest questions, it is more real than the thing you have been protecting by not asking them. The censored faith, the faith that survives only by not-looking, is not worth keeping even if it feels safer, because it is not faith in God, it is faith in your own avoidance, and avoidance is a poor god that will fail you the moment life forces the questions on you anyway, as life eventually does. Better to ask now, on your own terms, than to have the questions torn out of you later by a grief that gives you no choice.

*Your questions cannot kill God. They can only kill the idols standing between you and Him, and He has been waiting a long time for them to fall.*

So ask them. Ask the worst one, the one you have been holding back, the one you are afraid would end it all if you let yourself think it through. Ask it fully, all the way to the bottom, and stop protecting a God who does not need and never wanted your protection. If your faith cannot survive your hardest question, then it was going to fail you eventually anyway, at the worst possible time, and better to find out now, in the quiet, than at the graveside. And if your faith can survive your hardest question, if there is something at the bottom that holds, then you will have a faith you no longer have to protect, a faith that has looked into its own abyss and not been swallowed, and that faith is worth a hundred of the careful, anxious, unexamined thing you have been guarding. The God who can survive your questions is the only God worth having. The other one, the fragile one, the one you



have to protect, was never God at all. He was your fear wearing God's name, and the questions you were afraid to ask are exactly the fire that burns the fear away and leaves the real thing standing.

## Chapter Thirteen: Lament, the Language the Church Forgot

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There is a whole language in the Bible that the church stopped speaking, and its loss is one of the reasons your faith had no room for your pain. The language is lament, and it fills the Psalms, and it is the sound of the faithful accusing God, complaining to God, telling God to His face that He is absent and slow and seemingly indifferent, and doing all of this not as an act of rebellion but as an act of worship. The church cut this language out of its mouth somewhere along the way. It kept the Psalms of praise and quietly retired the Psalms of complaint, and in doing so it left you with a faith that had words for joy and words for gratitude and no words at all for the night your child was in the hospital and God said nothing. You were handed a vocabulary that could only speak upward when things were good, and when things were terrible you found you had been given nothing to say, and the silence you were left with felt like the absence of God, when it was really the absence of the language.

Let me show you what the church cut out, because you may not know it is in there. Roughly a third of the Psalms are laments. That is not a footnote. That is a third of Israel's prayer book, and they are not gentle. Listen to how they talk to God. Why do you stand far off. Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble. How long, O Lord, will you forget me forever. Awake, why do you sleep. You have made us like sheep for slaughter. My God, my God, why have you forsaken me. These are not the prayers of people whose faith was failing. These are the prayers of the most

faithful people in the history of the world, and they are prayers of accusation, of complaint, of a grief that turns and points its finger at heaven and demands to know where God has been. And here is the astonishing thing, the thing that should reorganize your whole understanding of what faith is allowed to sound like. God kept them. God put them in the book. God looked at Israel's furious, grieving, accusing prayers and said, yes, these, keep these, these are how my people should talk to me when the world is breaking. The complaint is canonized. The accusation is Scripture. Your fury at God has a home in the Bible, and the church hid the address from you.

Walter Brueggemann built much of his life's work on recovering this, and he argued that the loss of lament is not a small liturgical matter but a distortion of the whole faith. When a community loses the language of lament, he said, it loses the capacity to bring its real life to God, and so it must either bring a false, sanitized version of itself, all praise and no protest, or it must stop coming altogether. Those are the two exits, and you have probably taken one of them. Either you learned to perform the sanitized faith, to sing the happy songs on Sunday while your real life, the grief and the anger and the doubt, went unspoken and unattended, a whole hidden life that God was never invited into. Or you stopped coming, because you could not perform the happy version anymore and you had been given no other version to bring. Both exits are the fruit of the same theft. The church stole your language of lament, and then blamed you for having nothing to say to God in your suffering, or for saying, in your suffering, only goodbye.

I want to be very direct about why the church did this, because the reason matters. The church suppressed lament because lament is dangerous to a certain kind of religious order, the order

that depends on everyone appearing to be fine. Lament tells the truth about how things are, and how things are is often not fine, and an institution invested in the appearance of blessing cannot afford too much truth-telling about how things actually are. If the people started praying the honest prayers, started saying out loud in church how long, O Lord, and why have you forsaken us, the carefully maintained impression that faith produces a smooth and blessed life would crack, and the whole machinery of the prosperity-adjacent, everything-is-a-blessing, God-has-a-plan performance would be exposed. So the church chose the performance over the truth, and it chose it by editing the language, keeping the praise and dropping the protest, and it handed you a faith that could only be practiced by people pretending to be okay. And when you stopped being able to pretend, there was no room for you, because the room had been built only for the pretenders.

Now let me show you what lament actually is, because I do not want you to hear it as mere venting, as the therapeutic release of getting your feelings out, since that is not what the Psalms are doing. Lament is a form of faith, and it is a stronger form than the sanitized praise that replaced it, and here is why. To lament is to bring your accusation to God, which means you are still in the relationship. You do not accuse someone you have written off. You do not demand where were you from a stranger. The very act of crying out how long, O Lord, is an act of address, a turning toward, a refusal to let go of the God you are furious with. The atheist does not lament, because there is no one to lament to. Lament is the prayer of someone who still believes enough to be angry, who has not exited the relationship but is having it out inside the relationship, and that is a deeper faith than the smooth gratitude of someone who has never had anything to complain about. The Psalms of lament are faith at its

most muscular, faith with its fists up, faith that will not walk away from God even to escape the pain God has not prevented.

And there is a pattern in the laments that I have to show you, because it is the pattern that can hold your own life. Most of the lament Psalms do not stay in the accusation. They move. They start in the fury, they voice the complaint fully, they hold nothing back, and then, somewhere in the middle, often abruptly, they turn, not to a resolution of the problem but to an act of trust in the God they were just accusing. And I have come to see that this turn is the very shape of faith after suffering. It is not the turn of a problem solved. The problem is often not solved. The child does not always live. It is the turn of a person who has said the whole terrible truth to God and then, having said it, chooses to keep leaning toward Him anyway, not because the pain has been explained but because the relationship has survived the honesty. That is the load-bearing move. You can say the worst thing to God, the how-long and the why-have-you-forsaken-me, and the relationship holds, and out of the holding, not out of an answer, comes a trust that is stronger for having been through the fire. The sanitized faith never learns this, because it never risks the accusation, and so it never discovers that the relationship can bear it.

*Lament is faith with its fists up. You do not demand where were you of a God you have stopped believing in.*

So if the church left you speechless in your suffering, I want to give you back the language it stole. You are allowed to be angry at God. You are allowed to accuse Him, to tell Him He has been absent, to demand to know how long and why and where were you. This is not the failure of your faith. This is the oldest and most honest form of it, canonized in a third of the Psalms,

prayed by the most faithful people who ever lived, prayed in the end by Christ Himself, who took the opening line of the twenty-second Psalm onto His own lips from the cross, my God, my God, why have you forsaken me, so that the deepest lament in all of Scripture became the prayer of God to God in the moment of God's own dereliction. If the Son of God could pray a lament from the cross, then your lament does not put you outside the faith. It puts you in the deepest center of it, at the foot of the cross, saying the same words He said, and being heard the same way He was heard, which was not with an answer, but with a resurrection that came only on the far side of the cry. Say the words. He said them first. He will not be offended. He has been waiting for you to be honest enough to pray the way He prayed.

## Chapter Fourteen: What Should Actually Be Torn Down

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We have spent many chapters on the questions, and now the book has to turn, because a deconstruction that only ever tears down is not the thing I am arguing for. There is a demolition that is holy, and there is a demolition that is destruction, and the difference is what you tear down and what you leave standing. So I want to spend this chapter on what should actually come down, the things in your inherited faith that deserve the wrecking ball, the idols that were never God, so that in the next chapter I can be equally clear about what must not come down, the cornerstone that everything real is built on. If you tear down the idols and leave the cornerstone, you are doing the Spirit's work. If you tear down the cornerstone along with the idols, you have thrown out the one thing worth keeping. The whole art is in telling them apart.

Start with the biggest idol, the one hardest to see because it wore God's own face. The idol of certainty. You were taught that faith meant being sure, that a good Christian had answers, that doubt was failure and mystery was a gap to be closed, and this whole apparatus of certainty was itself an idol, a substitute for the living God, and it needs to come down. Certainty is a feeling, and you made a god of the feeling, and when the feeling left, you thought God had left, because you had confused the two. Tear it down. The living God is not the feeling of being sure. He is a person you trust in the dark, and the idol of certainty has to fall before you can meet Him, because as long as you demand certainty you will keep mistaking your own confidence for His

presence, and worshiping the confidence instead of Him. The fall of your certainty is not the fall of your faith. It is the fall of an idol that was standing where your faith should have been.

Tear down the political idol, and tear it down completely, because it is one of the most destructive things ever fused to the gospel in your lifetime. Somewhere the faith you were handed got welded to a partisan program, so that a set of positions became indistinguishable from Christ, and the kingdom of God got confused with the fortunes of a party, and the name of Jesus got stapled to policies He never endorsed and attitudes He explicitly condemned. That is idolatry, straightforward idolatry, the worship of political power under the name of God, and it has done incalculable damage, both to the people driven out by it and to the people captured by it. Tear it down. When you pull the partisan program off the gospel and throw it in the fire, you are not losing your faith. You are purifying it. You are doing what the prophets did when they smashed the idols the people had set up beside the true God, and the fact that this particular idol had a cross painted on it does not make it less of an idol. It makes it worse, because it took the Lord's name in vain on the largest possible scale.

Tear down the idol of the self-protecting institution, the one that taught you the church's reputation mattered more than the truth, that covering the scandal was serving God, that loyalty to the organization was loyalty to Christ. That is an idol, and it is the idol that abused the woman in the first chapter, the idol that asked her what she was wearing in order to protect itself, and it deserves the wrecking ball more than almost anything else in this book. The institution is not God. The institution can become the enemy of God, can crucify God, has crucified God, and your refusal to worship the institution is not the loss of your faith but



potentially its recovery, because you cannot see the real God as long as the institution stands where He should be, demanding the reverence that belongs to Him alone. Tear it down. Refuse to give the organization the loyalty that belongs to Christ. This is not rebellion. This is the first commandment.

And tear down the idol of your own image of God, the manageable one, the one who could be trusted to make suffering make sense, the vending machine who dispensed protection for good behavior. I told you in the first chapter that this god died in the rooms where I sat with unbearable suffering, and I told you I mistook his death for God's death. He needed to die. He was an idol, a god small enough to fit inside my need for the world to be fair, and a god that small cannot survive a world this large, and his death was not the death of faith but the clearing away of a false faith so that a truer one could be built. Tear him down. The god who guarantees your safety in exchange for obedience is not the God of the cross, who guaranteed no such thing to His own Son. Let that god die. Grieve him if you must, but let him die, because as long as he is standing you cannot see the crucified God behind him, and the crucified God is the only one who can survive the world as it actually is.

Let me say clearly what all these idols have in common, because seeing the common thread is how you find the others I have not named. Every one of them is a substitute for the living God that offered you something God does not offer, control. The idol of certainty offered you intellectual control, the comfort of never having to trust in the dark. The political idol offered you the control of power, the sense that you could seize the kingdom by force. The institutional idol offered you the control of belonging, safety through loyalty to a system. The manageable god offered you the control of fairness, a world that would reward you if you

kept the rules. Every idol is a bid for control, and the living God does not offer control, He offers Himself, which is a far more dangerous and far more precious thing, because a God you cannot control is a God who can actually love you, and a God you can control is only a mirror of your own fear. So when you are trying to tell whether a thing in your faith is an idol to be torn down, ask what it offers you, and if what it offers is control, tear it down, because control is what idols sell and the living God never does.

*Every idol is a bid for control, and the living God does not deal in control. He deals only in Himself.*

This is the demolition I believe in, and I want you to notice that it is a fierce demolition, not a gentle one. I am not asking you to make small adjustments to your inherited faith. I am asking you to take a wrecking ball to the idols, to be as ruthless with them as the prophets were, to pull down certainty and partisanship and institutional loyalty and the manageable god and every other substitute you have been worshiping, and to feel no guilt about the destruction, because the destruction is the work. The people who watch you do this will call it apostasy, and some of them will mean well and be terrified for your soul, and I want you to be gentle with them even as you refuse to stop, because they cannot tell the difference between tearing down the idols and tearing down God, since no one ever taught them the difference either. But you can tell the difference now. The idols are the things that offered you control. Tear them all down. And then, standing in the cleared ground, with all the false gods in rubble around you, you will finally be able to see the one thing that does not fall, the cornerstone the builders rejected, which is what the next chapter is about, and which you could never have seen while the idols were still standing in the way.

# Chapter Fifteen: What Must Not Be Torn Down

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Now the hardest chapter to write, because the whole book has been giving you permission to tear things down, and now I have to tell you what you must not tear down, and I have to do it without becoming the gatekeeper I have spent fourteen chapters refusing to be. But a demolition with no limit is not deconstruction, it is annihilation, and if I only ever hand you the wrecking ball I have not been honest with you, because there is a cornerstone, and the cornerstone is not an idol, and if you tear it down you will have nothing left to build on, and I will have helped you into the empty field I warned you about at the very beginning. So let me name what holds. Let me name the load-bearing things, the ones that are not wrapping, not culture, not idol, but the actual gift buried under all the packaging, and let me make the case for why these must survive the fire even when everything else burns.

The first thing that must not be torn down is the resurrection. I want to be blunt about this, because everything hangs on it. Christianity is not primarily a set of moral teachings or a philosophy of life or a comforting story, though it contains all of those. It is a claim about an event, that a man named Jesus was dead and then was not, that the tomb was empty, that He was seen, that death was defeated in a particular body on a particular morning. Paul says it as plainly as it can be said, that if Christ has not been raised, the whole faith is worthless and Christians are the most pitiable of people, and I want you to notice how much that concedes. Paul is not saying the resurrection is one

nice belief among many. He is saying it is the load-bearing wall, that if it goes the whole house comes down, and he says it because he is right. You can tear down a great deal and still have Christianity. You cannot tear down the resurrection and have anything left but a dead teacher's ethics, which is not the faith and never was. This one must hold, and the good news is that this one can hold, because it is not a feeling or a cultural preference but a claim about history, and claims about history can be examined, and this one has survived two thousand years of the sharpest people alive trying to explain it away.

The second thing that must not be torn down is grace, the scandalous center of the whole thing, the announcement that you are accepted not because of what you have done but because of what has been done for you. This is the part your inherited faith most likely corrupted, because the church is forever turning grace back into a transaction, forever adding conditions, forever making the free gift into a wage you have to earn by belief or behavior or belonging. And when you deconstruct, there is a danger that you will throw out grace along with the corruption of it, that having seen the transaction you will conclude there is nothing but transaction, and walk away from the one announcement that could actually heal you. Do not tear down grace. The corruption of grace, the works-righteousness, the earning, the conditions, tear all of that down, it is idol. But underneath the corruption is the real thing, the announcement that God's love for you is not a response to your performance, that it precedes anything you could do, that it held for you before you believed and holds for you now while you doubt. That is the gospel. That is the pearl. Everything else is negotiable and that is not, because a Christianity without grace is just religion, and religion is the thing you are right to be leaving.

The third thing that must not be torn down is the crucified God, and this is the one that answers most of the questions in this book, so I want to dwell on it. Through every chapter I have kept returning to the same figure, the God who does not stand outside suffering explaining it but enters it and bears it, the God who was Himself failed by the institution, Himself asked what He was wearing, Himself abandoned in the dark, Himself the pray-er of the deepest lament in Scripture. That God is the cornerstone, and He is why the faith can survive the questions that destroy the manageable god. Because when you ask where God was in your suffering, the crucified God has an answer that is not an explanation but a presence. He was in it. He is the God who has scars. Every other god that has been proposed to humanity stands outside suffering, above it, untouched, and can only ever explain your pain from a safe distance. This one has no safe distance. This one bled. And a God who bled cannot be disproven by your bleeding, because your bleeding is the very thing He shares. Do not tear down the crucified God. He is the only God who can survive a world with this much pain in it, because He is the only God who did not stay out of it.

Let me implicate myself here, because I nearly tore down the cornerstone myself, and I want you to know how close I came. In the depth of my own collapse, when the manageable god had died and I was sitting in the rubble, I came very near to concluding that since that god was false, all of it was false, that I should sweep the ground completely and walk away into the honest empty field. And what stopped me was not an argument. It was that when I swept away everything I could sweep away, when I tore down every idol I could identify, there was something that would not come down, and it was the figure on the cross. I could not make Him fall. Every objection I had was an objection to the god of control, the god of fairness, the god of

certainty, and none of my objections touched the crucified God, because He had already conceded everything my objections were based on. He had already entered the unfairness. He had already suffered the silence. He had already died the death that made the manageable god unbelievable. My deconstruction could get no purchase on Him, because He was standing at the bottom of it, having gotten there before me. And I realized that the whole time I thought I was tearing down the faith, I had only been tearing down the idols, and the cornerstone had been waiting under them, unmovable, the whole time.

So how do you tell the cornerstone from the idols, in the moment, when everything is coming down and you cannot see clearly. Here is the test, and it is the reverse of the test in the last chapter. The idols are the things that offered you control. The cornerstone is the thing that offers you the opposite of control, that asks you to trust what you cannot command, to love a God with scars whom you cannot use and cannot manage and cannot make safe. If a thing in your faith offered you power, certainty, safety, belonging on your own terms, it was probably an idol, tear it down. If a thing in your faith asks you to trust a crucified God in the dark, to receive a grace you cannot earn, to stake your life on an event you cannot prove but that will not stop confronting you, that is probably the cornerstone, and you must not tear it down, because it is the only ground the new house can stand on. The idols are seductive because they offer control. The cornerstone is hard because it offers none. And the whole maturity of faith is learning to prefer the hard thing that is real to the seductive thing that is false.

*You could not make the crucified God fall, because He had already conceded everything your objections were built on. He got to the bottom before you.*

I know that some of you, reading this, are afraid that I am doing the thing gatekeepers do, drawing a line and putting you on the wrong side of it, and I want to answer that fear directly. This is not a loyalty test. I am not telling you that you must affirm these three things right now or be cast out, because I know that faith comes and goes, that some of you cannot presently believe the resurrection, that grace still sounds too good to be true, that the crucified God is a figure you are only beginning to be able to look at. I am not policing your belief. I am telling you what the building is made of, so that when you rebuild, and I hope you will rebuild, you will know which walls are load-bearing and which were only decoration. Tear down whatever you must. Take all the time you need. But know, as you swing the wrecking ball, that these three are the ones that hold the roof up, and that a house built without them will not stand, not because a gatekeeper says so, but because they are the physics of the thing. The resurrection, grace, and the crucified God are not walls I am forbidding you to touch. They are the foundation I am begging you not to mistake for rubble, because everything you are hoping to build will need something to stand on, and this, only this, will bear the weight.

# Chapter Sixteen: The Wilderness in Between

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There is a place between the tearing down and the building up, and no one warns you about it, and it is the hardest part, and I have to spend a chapter on it because if you do not understand it you will mistake it for failure and give up in the middle of the very process that is saving you. The place is the wilderness, the in-between, the time after the old faith has fallen and before the new one has been built, when you have torn down the idols but not yet found solid ground under the cornerstone, when you can no longer believe the old way and cannot yet believe a new way, and you are just there, in the open, with no house and no map and no felt sense of God, and it feels like death because in a sense it is. Something has died and something has not yet been born, and you are in the gap, and the gap is real and it is long and it cannot be rushed.

The Bible knows this place. Its whole story keeps passing through it. Israel comes out of Egypt, out of the old bondage, and does not go straight into the promised land. It goes into the wilderness, into forty years of open, uncertain, unsettled wandering, and the wilderness is not a detour from the story, it is the story, it is where the people are formed, where the slave-mentality dies and something new is slowly born. The wilderness is not punishment. It is formation. And the mistake Israel keeps making, the mistake you will be tempted to make, is to want to go back to Egypt, back to the old bondage, because at least in Egypt there was food and certainty and a known shape to the days, and the wilderness has none of that, the wilderness has



only manna that comes one day at a time and a God who leads by a pillar you cannot predict. The temptation in the wilderness is always to go back, to rebuild the old faith exactly as it was, to return to the certainty even though the certainty was a kind of slavery, because the open uncertainty of the in-between is so hard to bear that even bondage starts to look good.

I lived in this wilderness for longer than I wanted to, and I am going to tell you the truth about it, which is that it did not feel like God was doing something in me. It felt like nothing. It felt like absence. The old felt sense of God's presence was gone, and no new sense had arrived, and I would pray and it was like speaking into a room I was no longer sure was occupied, and the temptation to either rebuild the old certainty or to give up entirely was constant, because both of those would have ended the unbearable openness of the in-between. And what I did not understand at the time, what I only understood later, was that the absence was not the absence of God. It was the absence of my old experience of God, which had been bound up with the idols, and when the idols fell the experience that came with them fell too, and there was a gap before the new experience could come, and in that gap it felt like God was gone when God was in fact doing the deepest work, the work that can only be done in the dark, the work Barbara Brown Taylor writes about, the formation that only happens when the lights are off.

This is the thing the church cannot help you with, because the church is built for the lit rooms, for the people who feel God's presence and want to sing about it, and it has almost nothing to say to the person in the dark except to try to turn the lights back on, to fix the darkness, to hurry you through it back into the felt certainty. But the darkness is not a problem to be fixed. It is a place to be inhabited. The old mystics knew this, they had a

name for it, the dark night of the soul, and they understood it not as the withdrawal of God but as a particular and advanced work of God, the stripping away of all the consolations and feelings and certainties a person had mistaken for God, so that they could learn to love God Himself rather than the feelings He gave, to trust in the dark rather than only in the light. The dark night is not the absence of God. It is the presence of God working in a mode too deep for feeling, and the people who flee it, who rush to relight the room, miss the very thing it came to give, which is a faith that no longer needs the lights.

So let me tell you how to be in the wilderness, since you cannot avoid it and you should not try. First, do not rush it. This is the hardest instruction and the most important. Everything in you and everyone around you will want you to get to the resolution, to be settled again, to have a faith to report, and the pressure to rush will be enormous, from your own discomfort and from a church that cannot tolerate your uncertainty. Resist it. The wilderness has its own time and it cannot be hurried, and a faith rushed to conclusion in order to escape the discomfort of the in-between will be a shallow faith, built to relieve your anxiety rather than to bear the weight of your life. Let it take as long as it takes. Second, do not go back to Egypt. Do not rebuild the old faith exactly as it was just to escape the openness. The old faith fell because it was fragile, and rebuilding it identically only schedules the next collapse, and the pull to go back will be strongest exactly when the wilderness is hardest, which is exactly when you must refuse it.

Third, and this is the one that kept me alive, learn to receive the manna. In the wilderness God did not give Israel a storehouse. He gave them manna, one day's worth, every morning, and it could not be hoarded, it rotted if you tried to save it, and they

had to gather it fresh each day and trust that tomorrow's would come. That is the spiritual discipline of the in-between. You will not be given a whole new faith all at once, a storehouse of certainty to carry you through. You will be given enough for today, one small mercy, one moment where the crucified God seems briefly real, one line of a Psalm that holds, one act of love that you cannot fully explain, and you have to learn to receive that day's portion and not despise it for being small, and not demand the storehouse, and trust that tomorrow's portion will come. This is a harder faith than the storehouse faith, and it is a truer one, because it is a faith that lives on trust rather than on supply, on the God who gives daily rather than on the certainty you can bank.

*The wilderness is not the absence of God. It is the absence of your old experience of God, and there is a difference, and the difference is everything.*

I cannot tell you how long your wilderness will last, and I distrust anyone who claims they can, because it is not a scheduled program, it is a formation, and formation takes as long as it takes. What I can tell you is that the wilderness is not the end of the story, that it is the middle, that Israel did come through it, that the in-between is a passage and not a destination even though it does not feel that way while you are in it. And I can tell you that the people who come through it, who do not rush it and do not go back to Egypt and do learn to receive the daily manna, arrive somewhere the people who never entered the wilderness can never reach. They arrive at a faith that has been formed in the dark, that does not need the lights, that trusts the God who leads by a pillar it cannot predict. That faith is the load-bearing one. It could not have been built anywhere but the wilderness, and the wilderness could not have felt like anything

but abandonment while it was doing its work, and the whole thing turns on your willingness to stay in the dark long enough for the dark to finish what it came to do. Stay. It is the hardest thing I will ask of you in this book. Stay in the wilderness. It is not empty. It only feels empty because you are being formed by a hand too close to see.

# Chapter Seventeen: Rebuilding on Rock

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Jesus ended the Sermon on the Mount with a story about two builders, and I have read it a hundred times, and it took my own faith falling apart before I understood what it was actually saying. Two men build houses. From the outside the houses may look identical, same walls, same roof, same doors. The difference is invisible until the weather comes, and the difference is the foundation. One built on rock and one built on sand, and when the rain fell and the floods came and the winds beat against both houses, the house on sand collapsed and the house on rock stood. And the point that undid me is this. Jesus does not say the storm only comes to the foolish builder. The storm comes to both. The rain and the flood and the wind hit the wise man's house exactly as hard as they hit the fool's. The difference was never whether the storm came. The difference was what the house was built on when it did.

I had spent years thinking the goal of faith was to avoid the storm, and the inherited faith encouraged this, promising that if you believed rightly and behaved rightly the floods would pass you by, and this was a lie, a sand-lie, and it collapsed the first time real weather came down on my life. The storm comes to everyone. The believer and the unbeliever both bury their children. The faithful and the faithless both get the diagnosis. Faith was never a shelter from the storm, and the version that sold itself as a shelter was built on sand and was always going to fall, because the storm was always going to come and expose that it had no foundation. What faith actually offers is not the

absence of the storm but a house that can stand in it, and the whole question of rebuilding is the question of what you are going to build your house on this time, now that you know the first house was sand.

So what is the rock. Jesus tells us plainly and we usually rush past it. The rock is not correct beliefs. The rock is not certainty. The rock is not even, exactly, faith in the abstract. Jesus says the one who builds on rock is the one who hears these words of mine and does them, and the rock is a relationship of trust and obedience to Him, a life actually staked on His words and not merely agreeing with them. This is crucial for the rebuilding, because it means the foundation is not a proposition you have to be certain of but a person you are learning to trust, and trust can survive uncertainty in a way that certainty cannot. If your foundation is being sure of a set of doctrines, then any doubt about any doctrine cracks the foundation, and this is exactly the sand your first house was built on. But if your foundation is trust in the crucified God, a leaning of your whole life toward Him, then your doubts about this or that doctrine can rage on the surface without touching the foundation, because the foundation was never the doctrines. It was Him.

This is the difference between the old house and the new one, and I want to make it vivid, because the whole hope of the book is here. The old house was built on certainty, which meant it had to be defended at every point, because any breach in the certainty threatened the whole structure, and this is why the inherited faith was so anxious, so defensive, so terrified of questions, so quick to expel the doubter, because it was a house of cards and it knew, somewhere, that it was a house of cards, and every question was a threat to the whole trembling stack. The new house is built on trust in a person, and it can hold questions the way a marriage

holds questions, without the whole thing coming down, because the foundation is not your being right, it is His being faithful, and His faithfulness does not depend on your certainty. You can rebuild a faith that welcomes questions instead of fearing them, that can lose an argument without losing its ground, that can say I do not know about a hundred things and still stand, because the one thing it is standing on is not the hundred things but Him.

Let me be practical about what rebuilding on rock actually looks like, because this cannot stay abstract or it helps no one. It looks like building your faith from the center outward instead of the edges inward. The old faith was often built from the edges, from the peripheral certainties, the young earth and the political positions and the cultural rules, and the center, the crucified and risen Christ, was assumed rather than examined, so that when the edges fell the whole thing fell because there was no examined center to hold. Rebuilding on rock means going to the center first. It means starting with the resurrection, with grace, with the crucified God, the load-bearing things, and getting those solid, actually staking your life on those, and then building outward from there, holding the peripheral things loosely, letting them be uncertain, letting them change, because they are not the foundation and they were never supposed to bear the weight. A faith built from the center out can lose any number of edge-beliefs and still stand. A faith built from the edges in falls the moment any edge cracks. Same house from the outside. Completely different physics.

I have to warn you against a false rebuilding, because there is one, and it is seductive, and it is the rebuilding that just relocates the certainty. Some people come out of the wilderness and rebuild a faith that is every bit as certain and defensive as the old one, just certain about different things. They were certain

conservatives and now they are certain progressives, certain about the old doctrines and now certain about the new critiques, and they have rebuilt on sand again, just a different beach, because the foundation is still their own certainty rather than trust in a person they cannot control. You can deconstruct a fundamentalism and reconstruct a fundamentalism of the opposite content, and it will fall the same way, because the problem was never the content of the certainty, it was the reliance on certainty itself as a foundation. Do not rebuild on sand of the opposite color. The rock is not being sure of the right things instead of the wrong things. The rock is trusting a person in the middle of not being sure of many things, and that is a completely different kind of ground, and it is the only kind that holds.

*The storm comes to both houses. Faith was never a shelter from the weather. It is a foundation that holds when the weather comes.*

So build the new house, and build it slowly, and build it on rock. Do not be in a hurry, because a house rushed is a house on sand, and you did not survive the wilderness in order to rebuild the fragile thing that fell. Go to the center. Stake your life on the crucified and risen God, on the grace you cannot earn, on the love that proved itself stronger than death, and get those things solid under you, actually solid, tested, staked-upon, not merely assented to. And then build outward from that center with a lightness you never had before, holding your other convictions with open hands, letting them be provisional, letting yourself be wrong about the edges without fearing for the foundation, because the foundation is no longer your being right. It is His being faithful. That is the house that stands. It does not look, from the outside, so different from the house that fell. But when



the weather comes, and the weather will come, you will feel the difference in your bones, because this time, when the floods rise and the winds beat against the house, you will still be standing, not because the storm passed you by, but because at last, and for the first time, you built on rock.

# Chapter Eighteen: Community

## When You Cannot Go Back

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There is a loneliness in deconstruction that no one prepares you for, and it may be the heaviest part of the whole thing, heavier even than the doubt, because we are made for each other and the tearing down of a faith is almost always also the tearing of a community, and you can lose your whole people in the process of finding your way to a truer God. You cannot go back to the old room. The people there cannot hold your questions, or they punished you for having them, or you can no longer sit through what is said from the front without something in you breaking. And so you are alone, and the church that talks constantly about community has, in your case, produced isolation, and you need somewhere to belong and the old somewhere is closed to you and you do not yet know where the new somewhere is. This chapter is about that, because a rebuilt faith that has no people is a house with no one living in it, and the faith the Bible describes was never a solitary thing.

Let me first grieve the loss honestly, because the church often rushes past it and I will not. When you leave a church, or a church leaves you, you do not just lose a set of beliefs or a building. You lose people. You lose the friends who cannot follow you where you are going, who now look at you with worry or with judgment, who pray for you in the way that means they have decided you are lost. You lose the belonging, the knowing and being known, the shape of your weeks, the community that showed up when your father died and celebrated when your child was born. That is an enormous loss, and it is a

real bereavement, and you are allowed to grieve it even if leaving was right, the same way you can grieve a divorce that was necessary or a move that was good. The people who tell you to just find a new church do not understand that you are not shopping for a service, you are mourning a family, and mourning cannot be short-cut by consumption. Grieve it. It was real. Something died.

And I have to say the hard thing to the churches, because I am one of the pastors who runs them. We did this. When a doubting person could not find room among us and had to leave to keep their integrity, that is our failure, not theirs. We built communities that could only hold the certain, that treated the questioner as a threat, that made belonging conditional on believing the right things in the right way, and so we manufactured the very isolation we then blamed the leaver for. A church that cannot hold a doubter is a church that has misunderstood the gospel, which is a message for sinners and strugglers and the unsure, not a club for the arrived. If you left because there was no room for your questions, the sin is ours. We should have been the safest place in the world to fall apart, and instead we were the place you had to leave in order to fall apart, and that is an indictment of us, and I will not pretend otherwise to protect the institution I serve.

But I did not write this chapter to leave you in the grief. I wrote it to tell you that the need for community does not go away just because the old community failed you, and that you must not let the failure of the old room convince you that you can do this alone, because you cannot, no one can, the solitary faith is a myth and a trap. The great temptation of the deconstructing person is to conclude that since the community wounded them, community itself is the danger, and to build a faith of one, a

private spirituality with no people in it, answerable to no one, accountable to nothing, and this is a subtle road to the empty field, because a faith with no community has no one to hold it up when you cannot hold it up yourself, no one to believe for you on the days you cannot believe, no one to be the body of Christ to you when you have lost the ability to see Him. You need people. The wound the old people gave you does not cancel the need. It just means you have to find different people, and finding them is hard, and I will not pretend it is not.

So where do you find them. Let me be honest that they are not always in the obvious places, and sometimes they are in surprising ones. Sometimes there is a church, a different kind of church, one that can hold questions, that does not require certainty for belonging, that has room for the doubter and the wounded and the one still in the wilderness, and if you can find such a church it is a great gift and you should let yourself receive it even though your instinct after being wounded is to trust no church at all. But sometimes, for a season, the community is smaller and stranger than a church. Sometimes it is two or three other people who are also in the wilderness, meeting in a living room, holding each other's doubts, being the body of Christ to one another without the building or the program. The Bible's promise is that where two or three gather in His name He is present, and it does not specify that the two or three must be certain, or must agree, or must have it figured out. It specifies only that they gather, and that His name is what gathers them, and a handful of doubters leaning toward the crucified God together is a church, a real one, sometimes a truer one than the building you left.

Let me implicate myself and my own network here, because I founded a network of pastors, thousands of them, and I have

watched what happens when leaders have nowhere to bring their own doubts, and it is a warning to everyone. Pastors are often the loneliest people in the church, because they are supposed to be the certain ones, the ones with answers, and so they have nowhere to take their own unbelief, and they carry it alone for years, performing a faith they have privately lost, until it destroys them or their ministry or both. I built the network partly because I knew this loneliness from the inside, the loneliness of the leader who cannot say I believe, help my unbelief from the front because the whole institution depends on his appearing sure. If even the pastors need a community where they can be honest about their doubt, then how much more do you, and the lesson is the same for all of us. No one can carry a faith alone, not the person in the pew and not the person in the pulpit, and the pretending-to-be-fine that passes for community in most churches is not community at all, it is a mutual performance, and it is precisely what has to be torn down so that a real community, one that can hold real doubt, can be built.

*A faith with no people is a house with no one living in it. You cannot do this alone, and you were never meant to.*

So do not settle for the solitary faith, however tempting it is after the wound, and do not go back to the room that could not hold you, however much you miss the belonging. Find the two or three. Find the people who can hear I believe, help my unbelief without flinching, without fixing, without deciding you are lost. They exist. They are often themselves survivors of the same tearing down, which is why they can hold yours, and there are more of them than you think, scattered and quiet, having learned the hard way that a community which cannot hold doubt is not worth belonging to. Building a new community is slower and harder than keeping the old one would have been, and it will take

longer than you want, like everything in this book. But a faith rebuilt on rock still needs a house full of people to live in it, and the finding of those people, the patient, grieving, hopeful finding of a new family after the old one failed, is not a distraction from your rebuilt faith. It is part of the rebuilding. The body of Christ was never a metaphor. It is people, and you need them, and they need you, doubts and all, because a doubt shared is a doubt survived, and a faith held by three trembling hands is stronger than a certainty held alone.

# Chapter Nineteen: The Faith That Holds Because It Was Tested

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I want to tell you about the difference between a belief you inherited and a belief you fought for, because they are not the same kind of thing even when they have the same content, and the whole promise of the far side of deconstruction rests on this difference. An inherited belief is a coat you were given. A fought-for belief is a coat you made, or at least a coat you patched and re-stitched with your own hands after the given one fell apart. They may look similar. They may keep you equally warm on a mild day. But when the real cold comes, the coat you made yourself, the one you know every seam of because you sewed them, holds in a way the given coat never could, because you know exactly what it is made of and exactly why it holds, and that knowing is itself a kind of warmth.

The inherited faith was untested, and untested is not the same as false but it is dangerously close to fragile. You believed because you were told, because everyone around you believed, because it was the water you swam in, and there is nothing wrong with beginning that way, everyone begins that way, faith is handed down and that is proper. But a faith that is only inherited, only handed down, only believed because it was received, has never been under load, and you do not know whether a structure will hold until it has been under load. The first house in the parable looked fine until the storm. Your inherited faith looked fine until the storm, and then it fell, and the falling was terrible but it told you something you needed to know, which is that the structure had never been tested and could not bear weight. Now, on the far

side, you have the chance to build something that has been tested, and a tested faith is a different animal entirely from an untested one, even if every belief in it is identical, because it has been under load and it held.

Let me tell you what testing does, because it is not just that a tested faith has survived, though it has. Testing changes the nature of the belief itself. Before my faith fell, I believed in the goodness of God, and I could have told you I believed it, and I would have meant it. But my belief in God's goodness had never been forced to reckon with a God who let a four-year-old die, and so it was a shallow belief, a fair-weather belief, a belief that had never met its own hardest counterexample. When my faith fell and I had to decide whether I could believe in God's goodness in a world with dead children in it, the belief either had to die or become something deeper, and what it became, when it did not die, was a belief in God's goodness that had looked directly at the worst thing and still, somehow, held, not because the worst thing was explained but because I had met the crucified God at the bottom of it. That belief is not the same belief I had before, even though the words are identical. The words are the same. The belief is made of completely different material. One had never been tested. The other had been to the bottom and come back, and it carries the bottom in it now, and it is unbreakable in a way the first one never was, because it has already survived the thing that would have broken it.

This is why I will not tell you to be sorry that your faith fell, and it is why the church's fearful response to deconstruction is so tragically wrong. The church sees the falling as pure loss, as damage, as a catastrophe to be prevented, and it does everything it can to keep people from the testing, to keep the faith untested and therefore, it imagines, safe. But an untested faith is not safe.



It is only untested, which means it is fragile, which means it will fall the first time real weight comes down on it, at the worst possible time, when the person is least able to bear the fall. The church, in trying to protect people from the testing, is actually condemning them to a fragile faith that will fail them in the emergency, and the deconstruction it fears is often the very thing that could have given them a faith that would hold when they needed it most. The testing is not the enemy of faith. The testing is what turns an inherited fragility into a load-bearing trust, and a church wise enough to understand this would not fear its people's questions. It would walk them into the testing on purpose, and hold them through it, and welcome them out the other side with a faith that could finally bear the weight of a human life.

I think of the difference between the disciples before the crucifixion and the disciples after the resurrection, because it is the same difference. Before, they believed in Jesus, sincerely, but their faith was untested, and when the storm of the crucifixion came it collapsed completely, they scattered, they denied, they hid, the whole structure fell in a single night. That was their deconstruction, forced on them by the death of everything they had believed, and it was total. But then came the resurrection, and the faith that was rebuilt on the far side of that collapse was a different faith entirely, a tested faith, a faith that had watched everything fall and then seen the risen Christ in the rubble, and that faith did not scatter when the persecution came. It went to the lions singing. The same men who fled a servant girl's question in the courtyard later faced execution without flinching, and the difference was not that they became braver. The difference was that their faith had been through death and resurrection, had been tested to destruction and rebuilt on rock, and a faith that has been to the bottom and come back does not flinch at the lions, because it has already met the worst and

found Christ there.

I have to be honest about the cost, though, because I promised not to flatter, and the promise of a tested faith can sound like a reason to want the testing, and I do not want you to romanticize what is actually a form of suffering. The testing is not pleasant. It is not a spiritual adventure you sign up for. It is your faith coming apart, and it hurts, and there is no guarantee, none, that you will come out the other side with the tested faith rather than with nothing at all. I have watched people go into the testing and not come back, and I will not pretend the outcome is assured, because it is not, and anyone who tells you deconstruction reliably produces a stronger faith is selling you a lie as false as the one that says it reliably produces apostasy. The testing is real testing, which means real risk, which means the possibility of real loss. What I can tell you is that the untested faith carries its own certain loss, the loss that comes when it fails under a weight it was never built to bear, and that between a certain fragility and a risky testing, the testing is at least the road that can lead somewhere solid. But it is a road with real danger on it, and I will not draw you onto it by pretending the danger is not there.

*An inherited faith is a coat you were given. A tested faith is a coat you know every seam of, because you re-stitched it in the cold.*

So if your faith has been tested, if it has been to the bottom and somehow come back, I want you to understand what you are holding, because you may not yet realize its value. You are holding a faith that has already survived the worst thing you could think of, and a faith that has survived the worst thing cannot be threatened by lesser things, which means you have a durability the untested believer does not have and cannot

understand. They will look at you, with your fewer certainties and your comfort with mystery and your refusal to pretend to know what you do not know, and they will think your faith is weaker than theirs, because it is quieter and less sure. They are wrong. Yours has been under load. Theirs has not. And when the day comes that theirs is finally tested, as everyone's eventually is, some of them will fall the way you fell, and if you have built well on the far side of your own falling, you will be exactly the person who can walk them through it, because you have been there, and you came back, and you can say to them the truest thing one deconstructed believer can say to another, which is not it will be fine, but rather, I have been where you are, and there is something at the bottom, and it holds.

# Chapter Twenty: How to Pray When You Are Not Sure Anyone Is Listening

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Let me get very practical for a chapter, because the whole book has been arguing that a rebuilt faith is possible, and now I have to talk about how you actually live it in the ordinary days, and the most ordinary and most difficult part is prayer. When your faith comes apart, prayer is usually the first thing to go, or rather it is the first thing to become impossible, because prayer requires believing that someone is on the other end, and the exact thing you have lost is the confidence that anyone is there. So you stop, or you keep going through the motions while feeling like a fraud, or you find yourself talking to the ceiling the way I described in the opening pages, the words still coming out of habit while the floor underneath has gone soft. This chapter is about how to pray in that condition, because I do not think you have to wait until your certainty returns to pray, and in fact I think prayer in the uncertainty may be the most important prayer you ever pray.

Start by throwing out the model of prayer you were probably given, because it is part of what has to be torn down. You were likely taught that prayer is a technique with reliable results, that if you pray rightly, with enough faith and the right words and no doubt, God will act, and this model is an idol, and it is a cruel one, because it makes every unanswered prayer your fault. Did you not have enough faith. Did you doubt. Did you fail to claim the promise. This model turns God into a machine and you into the operator, and when the machine does not produce the output,

the model blames the operator, and so people who prayed with everything they had for a healing that did not come are left believing that their child died because their faith was insufficient, which is one of the most monstrous things the church has ever taught, and it is a lie, and it needs to be torn down before you can pray honestly again. Prayer is not a technique for getting God to do things. If it were, the father in Mark would have been disqualified, because he prayed his mixed and doubting prayer and Jesus answered it anyway.

So what is prayer, if it is not a technique. Prayer is address. It is turning toward God and speaking, and the speaking does not have to be confident to be real, it only has to be honest and directed. And this means you can pray in the uncertainty, because the uncertainty does not prevent address. You can turn toward a God you are not sure is there and say, I am not sure you are there, and that is a prayer, a real one, maybe a truer one than the confident prayers you used to pray, because it is honest, and God has always preferred the honest prayer to the confident lie. The Psalms are full of prayers that begin in uncertainty and accusation and abandonment, and they are prayers, they are in the prayer book, God kept them, which means that a prayer does not require certainty about the God you are praying to. It requires only that you turn toward Him and speak the truth, whatever the truth is, even if the truth is that you no longer know whether He exists.

Let me give you the prayer that carried me through the wilderness, and it is not a prayer I invented, it is the prayer that this whole book is named after. I believe, help my unbelief. I prayed that, or some version of it, for a long time, when I could pray nothing else. On the days I could not muster belief, I could at least muster the honest report that I could not muster belief,

and I could turn that report into an address, could say to the God I was not sure was listening, this is where I am, I want to believe and I cannot, help me. And that prayer has a strange property, which is that it cannot be prayed insincerely, because it does not claim anything you do not have. It does not require you to summon a faith you lack. It only requires you to admit the faith you lack and to ask for help with the lack, and that is a prayer anyone can pray, in any condition, at the very bottom of the wilderness, and it is enough. It was enough for the father in Mark and it was enough for me and it is enough for you. You do not need a better prayer than that. You need only to pray that one, honestly, and keep praying it, and let it be the thread you hold in the dark.

Here is something I learned about prayer in the uncertainty that surprised me and that I have to pass on. The feeling of God's presence and the reality of God's presence are not the same thing, and prayer in the wilderness is the discipline of continuing to address a God whose presence you cannot feel, on the possibility that He is present anyway. For most of my earlier life, prayer had come with a felt sense of God, a warmth, a sense of being heard, and I had assumed that the feeling was the point and the sign that the prayer was working. And when the feeling left, in the wilderness, I assumed prayer had become pointless, that I was talking to no one. But the mystics and the Psalms taught me otherwise. They taught me that the felt absence of God is not the actual absence of God, that some of the deepest prayer happens precisely when the feeling is gone, when you are praying on bare trust rather than on warm feeling, when you say the words into the silence not because you feel Him there but because you have decided to keep addressing Him whether you feel Him or not. That kind of prayer, the prayer without the feeling, is not lesser prayer. It may be the truest prayer there is, because it wants God

rather than the feeling of God, and it is willing to keep speaking into the dark on the possibility of a presence it cannot confirm.

Let me be practical about the mechanics, because in the wilderness even the mechanics fail and you need something to hold. When you cannot pray your own words, pray someone else's. This is what the written prayers are for, the Psalms, the old liturgies, the prayers of the church across the centuries, and they are a gift precisely for the seasons when you have no prayer of your own. There were long stretches when I could not generate a single honest word toward God, and in those stretches I prayed the Psalms, said the words other people had written when they were where I was, let the ancient laments carry my prayer when I had no prayer, and this is not cheating, it is the oldest practice of the faith, praying with the words of the communion of saints when your own words have failed. And when even that is too much, when you cannot pray words at all, you can pray with your body, kneel, sit in silence, be present before the God you cannot feel or address, and let the being-present be the prayer. Prayer does not require eloquence or even words. It requires only that you keep turning toward Him, in whatever form you can manage, and refuse to stop turning toward Him even when the turning feels like turning toward nothing.

*You do not need a better prayer than I believe, help my unbelief. It cannot be prayed insincerely, and it has never once been turned away.*

So pray, even now, even in the uncertainty, even talking to the ceiling. Do not wait for the certainty to return before you pray, because the praying may be part of how the certainty returns, and even if it never returns in the old way, the praying is not wasted,

because prayer was never a technique for producing feelings or results, it was always just the turning of a creature toward its Creator, and that turning is real whether or not you feel anything come back. Pray the honest prayer, the mixed prayer, the prayer that admits the unbelief in the same breath as the belief. Pray the Psalms when you have no words. Kneel in silence when you have no Psalms. And trust, or if you cannot trust then merely hope, or if you cannot hope then merely act as though it might be true, that the God you are addressing in the dark is the same God who heard the father in Mark, who did not require him to resolve his doubt before He answered, who took the mixed and desperate and honest prayer and healed the boy. That God is not put off by your uncertainty. He is drawn to your honesty. Keep praying. It is the thread. Hold it, even when you cannot see where it leads, and especially then.



# Chapter Twenty-One: The Bible as an Ally, Not a Weapon

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I want to come back to the Bible, because in an earlier chapter I took apart the false model of it, the dropped-from-heaven idol that shatters the moment you read it honestly, and I owe you the other half of that, which is what the Bible actually becomes when you stop demanding it be the thing it never claimed to be. Because here is what usually happens in deconstruction. The Bible was used as a weapon against you, quoted at you, used to shame you and control you and shut down your questions, and so when your faith comes apart the Bible goes with it, becomes an object of suspicion, a thing you associate with the harm, a book you cannot open without hearing the voices that wielded it. And that is a tragedy, because the Bible was never meant to be a weapon, and when you learn to read it as an ally rather than a weapon it becomes one of the great companions of the rebuilt faith, and you would grieve to lose it if you knew what you were losing.

The Bible was weaponized against you, and I want to name how, because naming the abuse is how you separate the abuse from the thing abused. It was used as a rulebook, a collection of proof-texts, verses ripped from their context and fired at you to end arguments and enforce compliance. Someone wanted you to submit and they had a verse. Someone wanted you to feel ashamed and they had a verse. Someone wanted to shut down your hardest question and they had a verse, and the verse was deployed not to open up truth but to close down thought, not to invite you deeper but to make you stop. That is weaponized

Scripture, and it is a genuine perversion of the thing, because the book that was turned into a set of conversation-ending proof-texts is actually a vast, arguing, questioning, wrestling library that opens conversations rather than closing them, that contains more questions than answers, that models dissent and complaint and struggle on nearly every page. The people who used it as a weapon had to first flatten it into a weapon, had to strip out everything living in it, and hand you the flattened corpse and call it the word of God.

Let me show you the living book underneath the weaponized corpse, because it will surprise you if all you ever knew was the proof-text version. The Bible argues with itself. This is not a flaw the skeptics discovered, it is a feature the book proudly displays. Job argues against the theology of his friends, and God takes Job's side. Ecclesiastes questions almost everything the Proverbs assert, and the church kept both in the same book, side by side, the confident wisdom and the skeptical questioning of the confident wisdom, because the truth was in the tension and not in either pole alone. Jesus argues with the Scripture He inherited, deepening it, reversing it, saying you have heard it said but I say to you. The Bible is a two-thousand-year argument about God, conducted by people who did not all agree, preserved with its disagreements intact, and this is not a weakness to be explained away, it is the very thing that makes it able to hold your questions, because your questions are already in there, being asked by the writers themselves. The weaponized version had to hide this from you, because a book that argues with itself cannot be used to end arguments.

When you read the Bible as an ally, everything changes about how you hold it. You stop reading it as a rulebook to be obeyed and start reading it as a conversation to be joined. You find that

the questions you thought disqualified you from faith are being asked, out loud, by the psalmists and the prophets and Job and Ecclesiastes and sometimes by Jesus Himself, and you realize you are not standing outside the Bible with your objections, you are standing inside it, in a long line of people who brought exactly these objections to God and were not cast out for it but were canonized. The Bible stops being the voice that shames your doubt and becomes the record of a whole community's doubt, held across millennia, a companionship of the uncertain that reaches back thousands of years and includes you. That is the ally. That is the book the weaponizers hid from you. It is not a club to enforce certainty. It is a companion in the wrestling, and it wrestled long before you were born, and it kept the wrestling in the text so that you would know you were not alone in it.

I have to confess that I was a weaponizer, in my early years, because this book is nothing if I exempt myself from its indictments. I used the Bible as a weapon. I had my proof-texts, my conversation-enders, my verses to deploy against the doubter and the questioner and the one who did not comply. I ripped verses from their context and fired them, and I told myself I was defending the truth when I was actually shutting down thought, closing conversations the Bible itself would have opened. I handed people the flattened corpse and called it the word of God, and some of them, when they later read the living book underneath, felt betrayed, because the thing I had shown them was so much smaller and deader than the thing that was actually there. I have repented of this, and part of my repentance is this chapter, this attempt to give back the living book to the people I helped rob of it, to say, the thing I weaponized against you was never the real thing, the real thing is an ally, and I am sorry I hid it from you behind the weapon I made of it.

So how do you learn to read it as an ally, practically, after it has been a weapon. Slowly, and in large pieces rather than in fired fragments, and with the questions welcome rather than suppressed. Read whole books, whole arguments, rather than isolated verses, because the isolated verse is the ammunition of the weaponizer and the whole book is the country of the ally. Read the parts that were used against you and ask what they actually say in their context, and you will often find they do not say what the weapon said they said. Read the parts that were hidden from you, Job and Ecclesiastes and the laments, the questioning books, the wrestling books, and let them give you permission for your own questions. And read all of it through the center, through Christ, the crucified and risen one who is the lens the whole book is meant to be read through, so that when you hit the dark passages, the ones that were used to wound, you read them in the light of the God who died rather than in the shadow of the God who was invoked to hurt you. The Bible read through the cross is a different book than the Bible read as a rulebook, and it is the true one, and it is an ally, and it has been waiting to be your ally all along, underneath the weapon they made of it.

*The Bible was never a rulebook to end arguments. It is a two-thousand-year argument, and your questions were already inside it before you were born.*

I do not want you to lose this book. Of all the things deconstruction threatens to take from you, this is one of the ones I would most grieve to see you lose, because a rebuilt faith without the Scriptures is a faith cut off from the whole communion of the wrestlers who came before, a faith with no words for the wilderness, no laments for the dark, no record of the God who was found by the very people who accused Him. The weaponizers do not get to keep the Bible any more than the

hypocrites get to keep Christ. Take it back from them. Read it as the ally it was always meant to be, the companion in the wrestling, the long argument you are invited to join, the book that asked your questions before you were born and kept the questions in the text so you would know you belong. That book is worth keeping. That book will hold you in the dark. That book, read through the cross and joined as a conversation rather than obeyed as a rulebook, is one of the load-bearing gifts of the faith that holds, and I would not have you throw it out with the weapon they made of it, because the gift was always buried in there, underneath the flattened corpse, waiting for someone honest enough to read it whole.

## Chapter Twenty-Two: When Joy Comes Back

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No one tells you that joy comes back, and I have to spend a chapter on it, because if I end this book only with wilderness and testing and the hard work of rebuilding I will have told you the truth but not the whole truth, and the part I would have left out is the part you most need to hear on the worst days. Joy comes back. Not the old joy, not the naive joy of the untested faith, but a different joy, a stranger and deeper and more durable one, a joy that has been through the wilderness and carries the wilderness in it, and it is one of the surprising gifts of the far side, and almost no one warns you it is coming, so when it arrives it takes you by surprise, and I want to prepare you for the surprise so that when it comes you will recognize it and not be afraid of it.

Let me tell you about the joy that dies, first, because you have to understand what is lost before you can understand what returns. The inherited faith often came with a certain joy, and I do not want to dismiss it, because it was real, but it was a joy that depended on things being a certain way. It was a joy built on the belief that God had a good plan that would work out, that faithfulness would be rewarded, that the story would end well for you specifically, and it was a bright and confident joy, and when the faith fell that joy fell with it, because the beliefs it depended on had failed. And in the wilderness there is no joy, or almost none, there is a long grey stretch where joy seems like a thing that happened to someone else in another life, and you begin to believe that joy was part of the naive package you lost, that the price of your honesty is a permanent joylessness, that having

seen the world clearly you have forfeited the capacity for the happiness of those who have not. That belief is wrong, but it is a very convincing belief while you are in the middle of it, and I held it for a long time.

Here is what I did not know, and what I want you to know. The joy that comes back on the far side does not depend on the things the old joy depended on, and that is precisely why it is more durable. The old joy needed the good plan, the reward, the story ending well, and so it could be destroyed by a diagnosis or a death or a betrayal, by any evidence that the story might not end well for you. The new joy does not need any of that. It is a joy that has already looked at the diagnosis and the death and the betrayal, that has already been to the bottom of the wilderness, and that found, at the bottom, something that could not be taken away, and so it is a joy that cannot be destroyed by the things that destroyed the old one, because it is not built on their absence. It is built on the presence of the crucified God at the very bottom, and a joy built on that presence can coexist with suffering, can hold grief in one hand and joy in the other, can weep and rejoice at the same time, which the old joy never could, because the old joy required that things be well and the new joy requires only that He be present.

Let me be careful not to sound like I am promising a formula, because I have promised throughout this book not to flatter, and a chapter that guaranteed the return of joy would be a flattery. I cannot guarantee it. I can only testify that it happened to me, and that I have seen it happen to others, and that it is a real feature of the far side and not a sales pitch. The joy came back to me slowly, and it came back changed, and it came back in unexpected places, not in the triumphant moments where the old joy lived but in small and ordinary ones, in a meal with my sons,

in a line of a Psalm, in the particular quality of light in a room where the reading was good, in moments that had no reason to produce joy and produced it anyway, gratuitously, as a kind of grace. And I realized that the new joy was not tied to my circumstances the way the old joy had been, that it could arrive in the middle of a hard season for no reason I could name, and that this untethering of joy from circumstance was itself the gift, because a joy that does not depend on your circumstances is a joy that your circumstances cannot take away.

I think of the strange things the New Testament says about joy, that I used to read as pious exaggeration and now read as reports from the far side. Paul writing about rejoicing in suffering, James telling people to count it all joy when they meet trials, the whole counterintuitive insistence that joy and suffering are not opposites in the Christian life but can occupy the same moment. I used to think these were commands to fake a feeling, to paste joy over pain, and I hated them, because the pasted-on joy is one of the most oppressive things the church does, telling suffering people to smile. But that is not what these texts are describing. They are describing the joy on the far side, the joy that has been through the suffering and found something underneath it, the joy that is not the denial of the pain but the discovery of a presence in the middle of the pain that the pain cannot reach. That joy does not paste over suffering. It coexists with it. It is the joy of someone who has wept at the grave and, weeping, known that the crucified God was weeping too, and found in that companionship a joy that the grave could not defeat, because the grave, in the story this whole book has been circling, did not have the last word.

And I want to connect this joy to the resurrection, because that is where it comes from and that is the only place it could come



from. The whole reason there can be a joy that survives the worst is that the Christian story claims the worst has already happened and been defeated, that death itself, the final destroyer of all joy, has been beaten in a particular body on a particular morning, and so every subsequent instance of the worst is a defeated enemy, terrible but not final, painful but not victorious. The joy on the far side is resurrection joy, and it can only exist because the resurrection is claimed to be true, because if death is defeated then grief is real but not ultimate, then suffering is real but not the last word, then the wilderness is real but it is a passage and not a destination. Take away the resurrection and this joy is impossible, is mere denial, is whistling in a graveyard. Keep the resurrection and this joy becomes not only possible but almost inevitable, because a person who really believes that death has been defeated cannot finally be robbed of joy, since the thing that steals all joy has itself been overcome.

*The old joy needed the story to end well. The new joy has already been to the bottom, and found that the bottom was not the end.*

So on the worst days of the wilderness, when you have concluded that joy was part of the naive package and that your honesty has cost you your happiness forever, I want you to hold onto this even if you cannot yet feel it. Joy comes back. Not the old joy, which depended on things being well and could be destroyed by things going badly, but a new joy, a resurrection joy, which has been to the bottom and found something there and cannot be destroyed by the things that destroyed the old one. You will not manufacture it. You cannot summon it. It comes as grace, gratuitously, in ordinary moments, when you least expect it, and it comes changed, carrying the wilderness in it, weeping and rejoicing at once. And when it comes you will understand,

finally, why the people on the far side of deconstruction are not the grim and joyless skeptics you feared you would become, but are often, strangely, among the most joyful people you will meet, because their joy has been tested to destruction and rebuilt on rock, and a joy that has survived the worst is a joy that nothing can finally take, because it is built not on the absence of suffering but on the presence of the God who suffered, and rose.

# Chapter Twenty-Three: What You Give Your Children Now

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I have five sons, and I was raised without a father, and those two facts sit underneath everything I am about to write, so I will put them on the table before I begin. When your faith comes apart, one of the sharpest questions, sharper than most of the intellectual ones, is what you now give to your children, because you cannot hand them the faith you were handed, since it fell, and you are afraid to hand them nothing, since you know what nothing costs, and you do not yet have the rebuilt faith solid enough to pass on, and meanwhile they are growing, and the question will not wait for you to finish figuring it out. This chapter is for the parents in the wilderness, and it is for anyone who was handed a faith by parents who did not know it was fragile, which is to say it is for almost everyone.

Let me start with the fear, because it is a real fear and it deserves to be named rather than soothed. The fear is that if you do not give your children the certainties you were given, you will leave them defenseless, that the certainties, whatever their flaws, were at least a structure, and that a child raised without the structure will have nothing, will drift, will be worse off than you were. And underneath that fear is often a deeper one, which is the suspicion that maybe the whole thing is questionable enough that you have no right to hand it down at all, that passing on a faith you are unsure of to a child who trusts you is a kind of dishonesty, and that the honest thing might be to hand them nothing and let them choose for themselves when they are grown. I have felt both of these fears, as a father of five who was

in the wilderness while they were small, and I want to speak to both, because I think both are based on misunderstandings that a rebuilt faith can correct.

Take the second fear first, the fear that handing down an uncertain faith is dishonest, that you should give them nothing and let them choose. This sounds noble and it is actually impossible, because you cannot hand a child nothing. There is no neutral. If you do not hand them the faith, you hand them its absence, and the absence is not a blank space they will fill freely when grown, it is itself a formation, a way of seeing the world as one in which God is not spoken of, in which the ultimate questions are not asked, in which the transcendent is treated as unreal by the very silence that surrounds it. The child raised in the studied absence of faith is not a free agent choosing from a neutral starting point. They are a person formed by absence, as surely as the child raised in faith is formed by presence, and the parent who imagines they are giving their child freedom by giving them nothing is fooling themselves, because they are giving them nothing, and nothing is a something, and it shapes a child as powerfully as anything else. So the choice was never between forming them and leaving them free. It was only ever between forming them one way or forming them another.

That frees you to ask the better question, which is not whether to hand down a faith but what faith to hand down, and here is where the rebuilt faith becomes a gift to your children rather than a danger. Because you no longer have to hand them the fragile certainties that fell, the ones that would set them up for the same collapse you suffered, the young-earth and the culture-war and the God of control who guarantees safety for good behavior. You get to hand them something better, a faith built from the center out, a faith that welcomes their questions instead of fearing

them, a faith honest about what it does not know, a faith that will not shatter the first time they meet a hard fact or a hard experience, because it was never built on the pretense of having all the answers. You get to give your children the tested faith rather than the untested one, the load-bearing faith rather than the fragile one, and that is not a lesser inheritance than the certainties you were given. It is a far greater one, because it is a faith that can survive their own inevitable wilderness, which the certainties could not.

Let me be practical about what this looks like day to day, because the abstraction has to touch the dinner table. It looks like letting your children see you doubt and pray anyway, letting them watch a faith that includes I believe, help my unbelief rather than a performance of a certainty you do not have. My sons have seen me not know. They have seen me sit with hard questions and not pretend to answers, and they have seen me keep praying, keep going to the table, keep leaning toward the crucified God, in the middle of the not-knowing, and I have come to believe that this is a better thing to give them than the flawless certainty I could have performed, because the certainty would have set them up to think that faith requires having no questions, and then their questions, when they came, would have felt like the end of faith rather than a part of it. I gave them a faith with room in it, and I gave it to them by having a faith with room in it in front of them, because children learn what faith is not from what you say about it but from what they watch it be in you.

It also looks like refusing to weaponize the faith against them, which is the thing the church did to so many of us and the thing hardest to unlearn, because we do it by instinct, having had it done to us. Do not use God to control them. Do not use hell to

frighten them into compliance. Do not use verses to end conversations you find uncomfortable. Do not make their belonging in your family conditional on their believing the right things, because that is the exact machinery that drove so many of us out, the machinery that fused God with control and belonging with compliance, and if you rebuild that machinery in your own home you will hand your children the very idol you are trying to tear down in yourself. Give them a faith that is an invitation and not a leash, a companionship and not a control, a table they are always welcome at whether or not they can presently believe, and you will have given them something that can hold them even in the seasons when they cannot hold it, which is the only kind of faith worth passing on.

*You cannot hand a child nothing. The absence of faith is not a blank space. It is a formation, and it shapes them as surely as presence would.*

I was raised without a father, and I have thought a great deal about what a father is supposed to give a child, having received it from no one and having had to figure it out for five sons with no model of my own. And what I have concluded is that a father's deepest gift is not certainty but presence, not a set of answers but a reliable love that stays through the questions, and that this is exactly what the rebuilt faith gives you to give your children. You cannot give them a God of certainty, because you no longer have one, and you should be glad you cannot, because that God would have failed them as he failed you. But you can give them a God of presence, the crucified God who stays in the dark, who is present in the wilderness, who does not require them to be sure before He loves them, and you can give them that God by being, yourself, a parent of presence rather than certainty, who stays through their questions, who loves them without condition, who

leans toward the crucified God in front of them without pretending to a confidence you do not have. That is the inheritance. It is smaller than the certainties in one way and infinitely larger in another, and it is the only one that will hold when their own faith comes apart, as it may, and if it does, they will have watched you, and they will know that the coming apart is not the end, because they saw it happen to you, and they saw what was underneath.

## Chapter Twenty-Four: The Silence of God

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I have circled the silence of God throughout this book, and now I have to face it directly, because it may be the single hardest thing, harder than any intellectual objection, and it is the experience underneath so many deconstructions that gets translated into arguments because the silence itself is too painful to name. The silence is this. You prayed, and there was no answer. You reached for God in the hour you most needed Him, and there was nothing, no sense of presence, no word, no help, only the silence, and the silence was worse than a no would have been, because a no is at least a response and the silence is the absence of response, the sickening possibility that there was never anyone there to respond, that you have been speaking into an empty room your whole life. This chapter is about that silence, and I will not resolve it, because it cannot be resolved, but I will not leave you alone in it either, because there is company in the silence that the church rarely tells you about.

Let me first refuse the false comforts, because the church has a whole arsenal of them for the silence of God and every one of them is an insult to the person actually enduring it. God is always speaking, you just need to listen better. God was there, you just could not feel Him. God has a plan and the silence is part of it. God is closest when He feels farthest. These may contain fragments of truth but as responses to a person in the actual agony of the silence they are obscene, because they all make the silence your fault, a failure of your listening or your feeling or your faith, and they all rush to fill the silence with



words rather than letting it be what it is, which is silence, terrible and real. The friends of Job filled Job's silence with words, and God rebuked them for it. If you have been handed these comforts by well-meaning Christians, know that they were filling a silence that should have been honored, and that their words were for their own comfort, not yours, because the silence frightened them and they could not bear to leave it unfilled.

Now let me tell you the thing that actually helped me, which is not a resolution of the silence but a companion in it. The silence of God is in the Bible. It is not an aberration, not a sign that something has gone wrong with your faith, it is a recurring experience of the most faithful people in Scripture, and it is recorded there, on purpose, so that you would know you are not alone in it. My God, my God, why have you forsaken me, is not the cry of a faithless person. It is a Psalm, and it is the cry of Christ from the cross, which means that the silence of God, the felt absence of God, the agony of reaching for God and finding nothing, was experienced by God the Son in the moment of His death. Let that be as strange and as heavy as it is. The one moment in all of history when God was most present and most at work, the cross, the very hinge of salvation, was experienced from the inside as the absence of God, as forsakenness, as silence. If the silence of God could coexist with the deepest presence and work of God at the cross, then your silence does not prove God's absence, because the greatest silence in the story concealed the greatest presence.

I am not saying this to explain your silence away, because I promised I would not, and the parallel to Christ does not make your silence hurt less or answer the question of where God was when you needed Him. What it does is keep the silence from being the final proof you fear it is. You have been treating the

silence as evidence, as the thing that finally shows there is no one there, and I am telling you that the deepest silence in the whole of Scripture, the forsakenness of the cross, was not evidence of God's absence but was, hidden inside it, the very moment of God's most decisive presence and act. Which means silence is not reliable evidence of absence. It felt like absence to Christ. It was not absence. It was the hiddenness of a presence too deep and too strange to be felt as presence, a working of God in a mode that felt, from the inside, exactly like abandonment. And if that is true of the cross, it may be true of your silence too, and the silence you took as proof of the empty room may have concealed a presence you could not feel, working in a mode too deep for feeling.

Barbara Brown Taylor, in the book I keep returning to, writes about learning to walk in the dark, about a God who is present in the darkness in a way that is different from the God of the lit rooms, a God you cannot see but who is there, and she argues that our terror of the dark, our relentless insistence on light, has cut us off from a whole way of knowing God that is only available when the lights are out. The silence is the auditory version of her darkness. It is the mode of God's presence that does not announce itself, that cannot be felt or heard, that requires you to stand in the unknowing and refuse to conclude from the silence that no one is there. And she is honest, as I want to be honest, that this is hard, that it does not feel like presence, that walking in the dark is not the same as walking in the light and pretending otherwise is a lie. But she testifies, and I testify with her, that there is a God in the dark, a God in the silence, and that some things can only be learned there, in the place where you cannot see or hear Him and stay anyway.

Let me tell you what I finally did with the silence, because you

need something to do with it and not just something to think about it. I stopped demanding that it break. For years I had treated the silence as a problem to be solved, had thrown prayers and techniques and pleadings at it, trying to make God speak, trying to force the silence to end, and the harder I tried to break it the more crushing it became, because every failed attempt was fresh evidence of the empty room. And at some point, in the depth of the wilderness, I stopped trying to break the silence and started trying to stay in it, to be present in it, to keep addressing the God I could not hear without demanding that He answer, to sit in the silence the way you might sit in silence with a person you love, where the silence is not the absence of the relationship but a form of it. And when I stopped demanding that the silence break, it stopped being evidence of absence and became, slowly, something else, a space I shared with a God I could not hear, a companionship in the dark that did not require Him to speak in order to be real. I cannot prove He was there. I can only tell you that when I stopped needing the silence to break, the silence stopped being empty, and became instead the particular shape of a presence I had been trying to force into a form it would not take.

*The deepest silence in all of Scripture, the forsakenness of the cross, hid the deepest presence. Silence is not reliable evidence of an empty room.*

So if you are in the silence, if you have reached for God and found nothing and taken the nothing as proof, I want to offer you not a resolution but a companionship, which is all the silence permits and all I honestly have. You are not the first to endure it. The most faithful people in the Scriptures endured it, and Christ endured it on the cross, and it did not prove for Him what you fear it proves for you, because the silence He endured concealed

the salvation of the world. Stop demanding that your silence break, because the demanding makes it worse and the breaking is not in your power. Learn instead to stay in it, to keep turning toward the God you cannot hear, to sit in the dark with a presence you cannot feel and refuse to conclude from the silence that the room is empty. It may be the hardest faith there is, this faith in the silence, this leaning toward a God who does not answer. But it is the faith of the cross, where God Himself cried out and was met with silence and was not, in fact, abandoned, and where the silence, terrible and total, was the sound the salvation of the world made while it was being accomplished in the dark.

# Chapter Twenty-Five: Mystery Is Not the Enemy of Truth

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The faith you were given probably taught you to fear mystery, to treat every gap in your knowledge as a problem to be closed, every unanswered question as a threat to be neutralized, and this fear of mystery is one of the deepest reasons the inherited faith was so fragile, because a faith that cannot tolerate mystery must pretend to know everything, and a faith that pretends to know everything shatters the moment it meets the one thing it cannot know. So I want to spend a chapter recovering mystery, not as a dodge, not as the thing you say when you have run out of answers, but as a genuine and essential part of any faith that is telling the truth about a God who is, by definition, larger than the mind that contemplates Him. Mystery is not the enemy of truth. The refusal of mystery is the enemy of truth, because it forces you to fake a completeness no finite creature can have.

Let me distinguish two things that get confused, because the confusion is where the fear comes from. There is mystery as a dodge, which is real and which the church abuses, the move where a person invokes mystery to avoid a hard question they simply do not want to face, where mystery becomes the trump card that ends inquiry, the pious way of saying stop asking. That is a corruption, and you are right to distrust it, and it has been used against you, deployed to shut down your legitimate questions with a spiritual-sounding refusal to engage. But there is also mystery as a discovery, which is completely different, the mystery you arrive at after you have pushed a question as far as it can go and found, at the far edge of your pushing, a genuine

limit, a place where the reality is real but exceeds your capacity to fully comprehend it. That mystery is not a dodge. It is an honest report from the boundary of what a finite mind can grasp about an infinite God, and it is the opposite of the dodge, because the dodge refuses to push and this arrives only after you have pushed all the way.

Consider that every domain of deep knowledge ends in mystery, not just faith, and this should reframe your suspicion of it. The physicist who understands the quantum world best is the one most willing to say that at the bottom it becomes genuinely strange, genuinely resistant to the intuitions of ordinary language, mysterious in a way that is not a failure of physics but a finding of it. The person who loves another human being most deeply is the one most aware that the beloved exceeds their full comprehension, that there is always more, that a person is a mystery you never finish knowing, and this mystery is not the failure of the love but its depth. In every serious domain, mastery does not eliminate mystery, it deepens it, because the more you truly know of anything real the more you become aware of how much it exceeds your knowing. Only shallow knowledge imagines it has grasped the whole. Deep knowledge always ends at a horizon, and the horizon is not a wall but an opening, the place where the reality proves larger than the mind, which is exactly what you would expect if the reality is real and the mind is finite.

Now apply this to God, and see how the fear of mystery was actually a category mistake. If there is a God, an actual infinite God and not the manageable idol we make, then that God must, of necessity, exceed the full comprehension of any finite mind, and a God you could completely comprehend would by that very fact not be God but an idol scaled to fit your skull. So mystery is

not a bug in the knowledge of God, it is the signature of the real thing, the mark that distinguishes the true God, who exceeds you, from the false gods, who fit inside your certainties. The inherited faith, in demanding that you have no mystery, was actually demanding that you worship an idol, because only an idol has no mystery, only a god small enough to be fully grasped can be fully explained, and the very completeness of the explanation was the proof that the thing being explained was too small to be God. When your certainties shattered and mystery flooded in, you were not losing God. You were, for the first time, encountering a God big enough to be real, a God who would not fit in the certainties, and the flood of mystery was the sign of His actual size.

Let me implicate myself and the faith I preached, because I built idols out of my refusal of mystery. I preached a God with no loose ends, a God who could be fully systematized, whose every way could be explained, and I did it because mystery frightened me, because I had a professional and personal stake in appearing to have the answers, and so I closed every gap with an explanation and handed people a God who was complete, and therefore small, and therefore an idol. And when those people met the real mysteries, the suffering that would not resolve, the questions that would not close, the God who exceeded my tidy system, they thought they were losing their faith, when they were actually meeting, for the first time, a God too large for the system I had given them. I had inoculated them against the real God by handing them a fully explained idol, so that when the real God showed up in all His mystery they mistook Him for the death of the god I had described, and in a sense they were right, because the god I had described did need to die, being an idol, and the mystery that killed him was the doorway to the real one.

There is a freedom in mystery that the fear of it hides from you, and I want you to taste it, because it is one of the gifts of the far side. When you no longer have to pretend to know everything, when you can say I do not know about a hundred things and still stand, when mystery becomes a companion rather than a threat, an enormous weight lifts, the weight of maintaining a completeness you never actually had. The inherited faith was exhausting partly because it required you to defend a total system, to have an answer for everything, to never be caught not knowing, and this is a crushing burden, and it is a burden the real faith does not require, because the real faith is built on trust in a God who exceeds you rather than on comprehension of a system that does not. You get to not know things. You get to stand at the horizon and say, beyond this I cannot see, and it is well, because the God I trust can see beyond it, and my faith was never my seeing, it was my trusting the One who sees. That is freedom, and mystery is its door, and the fear of mystery was the thing keeping you enslaved to a completeness that was never real and never yours.

*A God you could fully comprehend would not be God. He would be an idol scaled to fit your skull. Mystery is the signature of the real thing.*

So make peace with mystery, not as a dodge but as a discovery, not as the thing you say to avoid the question but as the honest report from the edge of what a finite mind can grasp about an infinite God. Push your questions as far as they will go, all the way, refuse the pious refusals that shut down inquiry too early, and then, at the far edge, when you have pushed as far as pushing can take you, let the mystery you find there be a doorway rather than a wall, the place where God proves larger than your mind rather than absent from it. The people who cannot tolerate



mystery are condemned to worship idols, because only idols have no mystery. The people who can hold mystery, who can stand at the horizon and trust the One who sees beyond it, are the ones who get to worship the real God, the one too large for any system, too deep for any complete explanation, mysterious not because He is hiding but because He is infinite and you are not. That God is worth the loss of your false completeness. He was always on the far side of the mystery you were taught to fear, and the fear was the last idol standing between you and Him.

## Chapter Twenty-Six: The Harm You May Have Done

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This is the chapter I least want to write and the one I most need to, because a book about deconstruction that only ever positions you as the one who was harmed is telling half the truth, and I have promised the whole truth. Many of us who are tearing down a faith were, before we tore it down, agents of that faith, and in that role we did harm, and part of an honest reckoning is facing the harm we did and not only the harm that was done to us. I have to go first here, because I have done more of this harm than most of you, having been a pastor for years inside the very system I am now critiquing, and I cannot ask you to face your complicity if I will not face mine, so let me face mine, and then let me help you face yours, gently, because this is tender ground.

I did harm. I have said it in fragments throughout this book and now I want to say it whole. I preached a God of control who guaranteed safety for good behavior, and people believed me, and when their good behavior did not produce safety their faith collapsed, and I built that collapse into them. I weaponized Scripture, deployed verses to shut down questions and enforce compliance, and I taught people to fear their own doubts, and some of them, unable to bring their doubts to a community I had made unsafe for doubt, left the faith entirely, and I helped build the exit. I preached hell as a leash and taught children to fear the Father. I protected the institution over the wounded more than once. I fused the gospel with a culture and a certainty and handed people the fused mass and called it Christ, so that when they later pulled at the culture it felt like pulling at God, and the

tearing that has cost them so much was partly my doing, because I welded together what should have been kept apart. I am not the victim in every story. In some stories, I am the one who did the damage, and honesty requires me to say so before I say anything else in this chapter.

Now let me turn to you, gently, because you may have done harm too, and facing it is part of the rebuilding, and refusing to face it is a way of staying spiritually adolescent, forever the wounded child and never the responsible adult. If you were ever a serious participant in the faith you are now deconstructing, you probably passed it on, in some form, to someone. You may have discipled a younger believer into the same fragile certainties that later failed you. You may have used the faith to judge someone, to exclude someone, to make someone feel that their questions or their doubts or their very self were unacceptable. You may have been, for someone, the hypocrite whose failure damaged their faith, or the certainty-machine that had no room for their doubt, or the one who weaponized a verse against their pain. The faith that harmed you was carried and transmitted by people, and if you were one of the people who carried and transmitted it, then you were, for someone downstream of you, part of the harm, and an honest deconstruction has to reckon with that and not only with the harm done to you.

I want to be careful here, because this chapter could be misused, could be turned into a bludgeon that keeps wounded people trapped in guilt, and that is the opposite of my intent. So let me be precise about what I am and am not saying. I am not saying that your victimhood is fake, or that the harm done to you is cancelled by harm you did, or that you should feel so guilty about your complicity that you cannot attend to your own wounds. The harm done to you is real and deserves attention and

healing. What I am saying is that you are not only a victim, that you are also, like all of us, an agent, and that a fully honest account of your relationship to the faith has to include both, and that facing your own complicity is not an added burden but actually a form of freedom, because the person who can only see themselves as harmed is trapped in a kind of powerlessness, and the person who can also see themselves as an agent who did harm has recovered their agency, which is the beginning of being able to do differently.

Here is why this matters for the rebuilding, and it is not obvious, so let me make it clear. If you rebuild a faith while still positioning yourself exclusively as the one who was wronged, you will build a faith organized around your own innocence, and a faith organized around your own innocence is a fragile and self-righteous thing, because it has no room for grace, since grace is only needed by the guilty. The gospel is good news for sinners, and if you have written yourself out of the category of sinner, if you are only ever the sinned-against, then the gospel has nothing to offer you, because you have no need of the forgiveness that is its center. Facing your own complicity, then, is not just an ethical duty, it is the doorway back to grace, because it is only when you can see yourself as one who has done harm, and not only suffered it, that you can receive the grace that this whole book has insisted is the load-bearing center, the grace that meets the guilty, the grace you cannot need until you admit you are among the guilty and not only among the wronged.

And there is a mercy in this that I want you to see, because the chapter cannot end in mere accusation. The same grace that meets your complicity is the grace that met mine, and I have to tell you that facing my own harm, the real harm I did as a pastor inside the broken system, was not finally crushing but freeing,

because it drove me back to the one thing the fragile faith never had, which was grace for the perpetrator and not just comfort for the victim. When I could no longer pretend I was only the wounded one, when I had to face that I was also the one who wounded, I discovered that the gospel had been waiting there the whole time with exactly what I needed, which was not the reassurance of my innocence but the forgiveness of my guilt, and the forgiveness of guilt is a stronger and stranger and more durable thing than the reassurance of innocence, because it does not depend on the lie that you did no wrong. I did wrong. So did you, probably. And the crucified God did not die for the innocent, of whom there are none, but for the guilty, of whom we are all, and that is either the worst news or the best, depending on whether you are willing to leave the category of the merely wronged and admit you belong to the guilty too.

*The person who can only see themselves as harmed is trapped in powerlessness. The person who can also face the harm they did has recovered their agency, and found the door back to grace.*

So face it, the harm you may have done, not to crush yourself under it but to find the grace on the far side of it, the grace that a faith organized around your innocence could never reach. Face the people you disciplined into fragility, the ones you judged, the ones you excluded, the one for whom you were the hypocrite or the certainty-machine or the weaponizer of verses. Own it, as I have tried to own mine, not with the false humility that secretly wants to be told you were not so bad, but with the real honesty that says, I did this, I was part of the harm, and I need the same grace I once withheld from others. Because that grace is there, and it is the center of the faith that holds, and it is available to you not as the innocent victim you have been telling yourself

you are but as the guilty and forgiven agent you actually are,  
which is the only kind of person the gospel was ever addressed  
to, and the only kind, in the end, that any of us has ever been.

## Chapter Twenty-Seven: What I Learned as an Atheist

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I have mentioned throughout this book that I came to faith from atheism, and I have used it as a credential, a way of telling you that I know unbelief from the inside and am not afraid of your questions because I once asked them all myself. But I have not yet told you what I actually learned in those years, and I want to, because the empty field I keep warning you about is a place I lived, and I did not just visit it, I made my home there for a long time, and I know its country, and there are things about it that the people who have never lived there do not understand, and there are things about it that the people who are fleeing toward it do not yet know. This chapter is my report from the country of unbelief, written by someone who lived there and left, and I want it to be honest about both what was true there and what was not.

Let me first defend the atheists against the caricature the church makes of them, because the caricature is a lie and it dishonors people I once was and still respect. The church often tells itself that people become atheists because they want to sin, because they are running from God, because they are angry or wounded or intellectually lazy, and while any of these can be true of a particular person, as a general account of unbelief it is false, and self-serving, and it is one of the reasons the church cannot speak to unbelievers, because it has decided in advance that it knows their motives better than they do. Many atheists I knew, and the atheist I was, arrived at unbelief through genuine intellectual honesty, through a real inability to believe things that seemed to them unsupported, through a refusal to pretend to a certainty

they did not have. There was integrity in it. There was courage in it, the courage to face a universe with no guaranteed meaning and not flinch, to give up the comforts of faith because they seemed untrue, and to prefer a hard truth to a soft lie. I respect that still. It is more honest than a great deal of what passes for faith.

But I have to tell you what I did not see while I was there, what only became visible from outside, because you are considering moving to that country and you deserve a full report and not just the brochure. What I did not see, while I was an atheist, was that my unbelief was not the pure, presuppositionless conclusion of reason I imagined it to be, but was itself a faith, a set of commitments I could not prove, held with a confidence the evidence did not warrant. I believed that the physical was all there is, and I called this a finding of science, but it was not a finding of science, it was a philosophical assumption I had smuggled in and mistaken for a discovery. I believed that the universe was meaningless, and I called this facing reality, but the meaninglessness was not something I had found, it was something I had decided, a conclusion I brought to the universe rather than one I read off of it. My atheism was not the absence of faith. It was a different faith, with its own unprovable commitments, its own leaps, its own things taken on trust, and I could not see this from the inside because I had defined faith as the thing the religious people had and reason as the thing I had, and this definition hid from me the faith at the bottom of my own reason.

And there was something else I did not see, harder to name, which was the cost of the meaninglessness on the parts of my life that were not arguments. In my arguments, the meaninglessness was fine, was even bracing, a clean cold truth I



was proud to face. But my life was not only arguments. My life included love, and beauty, and grief, and the birth of a child, and the death of people I loved, and in those places the meaninglessness was not bracing, it was corrosive, because it told me that the love was only chemistry, that the beauty was only the accident of a brain shaped by survival, that the grief was for a person who was now simply not, gone into a nothing that our whole relationship had been heading toward the whole time. I could hold the meaninglessness in my head. I could not hold it in the room where my grief was, because in that room the meaninglessness was not a truth I was facing but an acid eating the very things that made the room worth being in. And I began to notice a gap between what I believed and what I could live, between the meaninglessness my mind affirmed and the meaning my life kept insisting on, and that gap was one of the cracks through which, eventually, something else came in.

I am not offering this as an argument for God, and I want to be careful, because the church loves to argue that atheists secretly believe or that the emptiness of unbelief proves faith true, and neither of those is a good argument and I will not make them. The corrosiveness of meaninglessness on the parts of life that are not arguments does not prove that meaning is real, any more than the comfort of faith proves that God is real. It is possible that the universe is meaningless and that this is simply a hard truth we are poorly equipped to live with, and intellectual honesty requires me to hold that possibility open even now. What I am offering is narrower, and it is this. The empty field is not the neutral, obvious, courageous default that it presents itself as. It is its own country, with its own faith-commitments and its own costs, and the cost, in my experience, was not paid in the currency of argument, where the field seemed fine, but in the currency of lived life, where the meaninglessness kept trying to

dissolve the very things that made life worth living. And if you are fleeing toward the empty field imagining it is the place of pure honesty with no costs, I am telling you, as someone who lived there, that it has costs, and they come due not in the seminar room but at the graveside.

Here is the thing that finally cracked my unbelief, and I offer it not as proof but as testimony, because that is all I honestly have. It was not an argument. I had all the arguments, on both sides, and arguments alone had never moved me and did not move me then. What moved me was that the meaning my life kept insisting on, in love and beauty and grief, began to seem more real, more trustworthy, more like data, than the meaninglessness my philosophy had assumed, and I began to wonder whether I had gotten it backward, whether the meaning was the reality and the meaninglessness was the assumption, whether the love and the beauty and the unbearable weight of a human death were not illusions to be explained away by chemistry but were rather the truest things I knew, pointing at a reality my philosophy had ruled out in advance. And once I let myself take the meaning as data rather than illusion, the whole edifice of my unbelief, which had seemed like the conclusion of reason, revealed itself as the conclusion of an assumption, and the assumption began to look less certain than the meaning it had been dismissing, and through that crack, slowly, against my will and my arguments, something came in that I have been trying to describe ever since, and that I met most clearly, in the end, in the figure of the crucified God.

*The empty field is not the neutral default it pretends to be. It is its own country, with its own faith and its own costs, and the costs come due at the graveside.*

So when you flee toward the empty field, I want you to go with

open eyes, knowing the country you are entering, because I lived there and I am not going to pretend it is the simple honest nothing it advertises itself as. It is a real place and some honest people live there and I respect them, and I will not tell you they are fools or that they secretly believe, because that is a lie the church tells to comfort itself. But I will tell you that the field has its own faith at the bottom of it, its own unprovable commitments dressed as findings, and its own costs that do not show up in the arguments but show up in the living, in the places where love and grief and beauty keep insisting on a meaning the field has ruled out. I lived there. I left. And I left not because the arguments defeated me but because the meaning that my life would not stop insisting on came to seem truer than the meaninglessness I had assumed, and because, at the very bottom of my honest looking, there turned out to be something in the field after all, something I had declared could not be there, standing in the empty place with scars on His hands, having gotten to the bottom of the emptiness before me, and waiting.

# Chapter Twenty-Eight: The Church That Could Exist

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I have spent a great deal of this book indicting the church, and the indictment was necessary and I stand by every word of it, but a book that only indicts the church and never imagines what the church could be has done only half its work, because the wound of deconstruction is often a wound about the church specifically, and the healing has to include some vision of a church worth belonging to, or else the healing leaves you with a private faith and no home. So I want to imagine, in this chapter, the church that could exist, the church that would not have wounded the people this book is written for, the church that could hold a deconstructing person rather than driving them out, and I want to imagine it concretely, because a vague ideal helps no one and I am not interested in a vague ideal. I am a pastor. I have to build something on Monday. So let me imagine what I am trying to build.

The church that could exist would be a place where doubt is not a threat but a normal part of the life of faith, where a person could stand up and say I believe, help my unbelief and be met not with alarm but with recognition, because everyone in the room would know that sentence from the inside. This church would not require certainty for belonging. It would understand that faith is a posture of trust and not a state of certainty, and it would make room, real room, structural room, for people in every condition of belief and unbelief, the certain and the doubting and the barely holding on and the not sure they believe anything at all, and it would call all of them by the same name,

which is us. In this church the doubter would not be a problem to be fixed or a project to be converted back to certainty but a full member of the body, because the body was always made of people at different points, and a church that can only hold the certain is not a fuller church, it is an amputated one, having cut off the very members Christ was most tender toward.

This church would tell the truth about suffering, would have recovered the language of lament that the church forgot, would let its people say the honest prayers, the how-long and the why-have-you-forsaken-me, out loud, together, in the gathered worship and not only in private despair. It would not perform the everything-is-blessed act that drives suffering people out, would not paper over grief with premature praise, would not tell the person whose child died that God had a plan. It would sit with them in the ashes the way Job's friends did before they opened their mouths, when they were still being good friends, when they sat with him in silence for seven days because they saw that his suffering was very great. This church would know how to sit in silence with the suffering, would have the courage to not-explain, would trust that its presence in the dark was worth more than its answers in the light, and it would thereby be a place where a person could bring the whole of their life, the grief as well as the joy, and not have to leave the grief at the door.

This church would refuse to weaponize the faith, would never use hell as a leash or verses as conversation-enders or belonging as a bribe for compliance. It would tear down the idol of the self-protecting institution, would put the wounded ahead of its own reputation, would believe the one who came forward with a story of harm rather than asking what they were wearing. When it failed, and it would fail, because it would be made of people, it would repent publicly and specifically rather than manage the

scandal and protect the brand. It would treat its own power as a danger to be watched rather than a possession to be guarded, would remember that its Lord washed feet and warned against lording it over others, and would structure itself, as far as fallen institutions can, to resist the accumulation of unaccountable power that has produced so much of the harm this book has cataloged. It would be, in a word, a safe place to be unsafe, a place where the vulnerable were protected rather than exploited, which is the bare minimum the church owes and has so catastrophically failed to provide.

Let me be honest about the difficulty, because I am describing something and I have to build it and I know how hard it is, so I will not pretend it is easy. A church that holds doubt is harder to run than a church that requires certainty, because certainty is efficient and doubt is messy, and a room full of people at different points of belief is harder to lead than a room full of people who all affirm the same things. A church that tells the truth about suffering is harder to market than a church that promises blessing, because the blessing sells and the truth does not. A church that refuses to weaponize the faith gives up the tools of control that make institutions grow, and it will often be smaller and slower and less impressive than the churches that keep those tools. So the church that could exist is not the church that will win, by the metrics the church has wrongly adopted, and building it means accepting that you are building something that may look like failure by those metrics, and doing it anyway, because those metrics were never the point and adopting them was part of how the church became the thing this book has had to indict.

I want to tell you that this church is not merely hypothetical, that pieces of it exist, that I have seen them, because I do not want to

leave you with an ideal that seems impossibly far from any real community you could actually find. I have seen churches that hold doubt, that have recovered lament, that protect the vulnerable, that repent publicly, that tell the truth about suffering. They are not perfect, because nothing made of people is perfect, but they exist, in fragments and in whole communities, more of them than the wounded person dares to hope, often quiet and unimpressive and off the radar of the church-growth machine precisely because they have refused its tools. And I am trying, with the community I serve and the network of pastors I have gathered, to build more of them, to help leaders imagine that a church that holds doubt is not a failure of a church but perhaps a truer one, to give the deconstructing person somewhere to land that is not the empty field and not the room that wounded them but a third thing, a church rebuilt on rock, that could be a home for a faith rebuilt on rock.

*A church that can only hold the certain is not a fuller church. It is an amputated one, having cut off the members Christ was most tender toward.*

So if you have concluded that the church is irredeemable, that the harm it did to you is the whole truth about it, that there is nothing there worth returning to in any form, I want to gently ask you to hold that conclusion a little more loosely, not because the harm was not real, it was, but because the church that harmed you is not the only church that can exist, and the church that could exist is worth wanting, worth looking for, worth helping to build. Do not let the worst version of the church be the final word on what the church is, any more than you let the hypocrites be the final word on Christ. The church that wounded you was a real church and it does not get to define the church forever, and there is another church, some of it already real and some of it

still to be built, that could be a home for exactly the faith you are trying to rebuild, a home for the doubter and the wounded and the one still in the wilderness, a safe place to be unsafe, a body that holds its members at every point of belief. That church is worth wanting. I am trying to build it. Come help, if you can, because we need people who know from the inside what the old church did wrong, and who else would build the new one but the ones it wounded.



# Chapter Twenty-Nine: The One Thing Worth Examining

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I have told you that the resurrection is the load-bearing wall, the thing that must not be torn down, and I have asked you to trust me on that, but trust is not enough for something this important, so in this chapter I want to actually look at it, to make the case that the resurrection is not merely a comforting belief you should keep for pragmatic reasons but a claim about history that can bear the weight of your examination. Because here is the strange gift of Christianity, the thing that makes it different from a philosophy or a mythology. It stakes itself on an event, and events can be investigated, and so unlike a faith that asks you to believe things beyond all evidence, Christianity points at a specific claim in the specific past and says, examine this, because if this did not happen the whole thing is worthless, and if this did happen the whole thing is true. That is a remarkable thing for a faith to do. It hands you the knife and shows you where to cut.

Paul, writing to the Corinthians only about twenty-five years after the crucifixion, does the most un-mythological thing imaginable. He lists witnesses. He says the risen Christ appeared to Peter, then to the twelve, then to more than five hundred at once, most of whom, he says, are still alive, which is an extraordinary thing to write, because it is an invitation to check. He is not saying, believe this beautiful story. He is saying, there are hundreds of people walking around right now who claim to have seen this, go ask them. That is not how myths talk. Myths are set once upon a time in a faraway place with no witnesses to

interrogate. This is set last month, down the road, with a list of names, most of them still available for questioning. Whatever you conclude about what actually happened, you have to reckon with the fact that the earliest Christians did not treat the resurrection as a symbol or a spiritual metaphor but as a public event with living witnesses, and they staked their lives on it in a way people do not stake their lives on what they know to be a metaphor.

And that staking of their lives is itself a piece of the evidence that has to be explained. Something happened to the followers of Jesus after His death that turned them from a scattered, terrified, defeated group, hiding behind locked doors, their leader executed and their hopes destroyed, into a movement of people who proclaimed His resurrection in the very city where He had been killed, weeks after He had been killed, in front of the authorities who had killed Him, and who went to torture and death rather than deny it. People do not do that for a lie they invented. Liars, when the cost gets high enough, recant, because they know it is a lie and a lie is not worth dying for. These people did not recant, in numbers, under torture, over decades, which does not prove the resurrection happened but does prove that they sincerely believed it happened, that they were not knowing frauds, that whatever they saw or thought they saw, they were convinced of it to the point of death. So the question is not, were they lying, because the evidence says they were not lying, they believed it. The question is, what could have convinced a group of defeated, grieving, frightened people so completely that they would die for it, and the explanations that avoid the resurrection have to account for that, and they struggle to.

Let me be fair and intellectually honest, because I promised I would be, and I will not overstate the case the way apologists

sometimes do. The historical evidence does not prove the resurrection with the certainty of a mathematical proof, and anyone who tells you it does is overselling. It is possible to construct alternative explanations, mass hallucination, legendary development, deliberate fraud despite the difficulties, and I am not going to pretend these can be dismissed with a wave. What I am claiming is narrower and, I think, defensible. The resurrection is a serious historical hypothesis, taken seriously by serious historians, that accounts for the evidence, the empty tomb, the appearances, the transformation of the disciples, the explosive birth of the church, better than its rivals do, and that a reasonable person, examining the evidence honestly, can conclude that it is more likely than not to have happened, or at the very least that it cannot be dismissed as the obvious fiction the skeptical culture assumes it to be. You are not required to check your brain at the door to believe the resurrection. That is the claim. It is a claim you can investigate, and the investigation does not embarrass the faith, which is more than can be said for many things you were taught.

Why does this matter so much for the deconstructing person specifically. It matters because of everything else in this book. I have asked you to tear down a great deal, the idols and the certainties and the cultural wrapping, and you may rightly worry that once the tearing down starts it will not stop, that there will be nothing left, that the empty field is where all honest tearing-down ends. And the resurrection is the answer to that fear, because it is a place where the tearing down hits something solid, a claim that does not dissolve under examination but grows more interesting the harder you look, an event in history that the acid of your questions cannot fully dissolve because it is not a feeling or a cultural preference or a fragile certainty but a claim about something that either happened or did not, in the past, in a way

that examination clarifies rather than destroys. When you are afraid that honest inquiry leads only to nothing, the resurrection is the place where honest inquiry leads to something, and it is the reason I can promise you that the far side of deconstruction is not necessarily the empty field, because there is at least one load-bearing thing that the tearing down runs into and cannot tear down, and everything else can be rebuilt around it.

I met the resurrection, in my own return from atheism, not as a comforting story I wanted to be true but as a historical claim I could not dismiss as easily as I had assumed. I had believed, as an atheist, that no thinking person could take the resurrection seriously, that it was obviously a legend, and when I actually examined it, expecting to confirm my dismissal, I found instead a claim far more serious and far harder to explain away than I had been led to believe, and the difficulty of explaining it away was one of the cracks through which my unbelief began to fail. I am not telling you that the examination will produce faith, because faith is more than the conclusion of an argument and the resurrection can be granted as probable without the granting becoming trust. But I am telling you that the examination will not embarrass you, that you can look at the one thing worth examining with your full intelligence engaged and your skepticism operating, and that it will hold up under the looking better than almost anything you were taught, which is exactly what you would want to be true of the one load-bearing wall of the whole structure.

*Christianity stakes itself on an event, and hands you the knife, and shows you where to cut. No myth has ever done that.*

So examine it. Of all the things I have asked you to do in this

book, this is the one I ask with the most confidence, because this is the one where honest examination serves faith rather than threatening it. Do not take the resurrection on the say-so of the people who wounded you, and do not dismiss it on the say-so of the skeptical culture that assumes it is obviously false. Look at it yourself, with your full intelligence, the empty tomb and the witnesses and the transformed disciples and the explosive birth of the church in the city where its founder was killed, and ask what best explains it, and hold the resurrection hypothesis alongside its rivals and weigh them honestly. I cannot make the examination come out one way, and I will not pretend the conclusion is forced. But I can tell you that this is the one thing in the whole edifice that grows more solid the harder you look, the one wall the acid does not dissolve, and if you are rebuilding a faith and looking for something to build it on that will not wash out from under you, this is where the ground stops being sand and becomes rock. Start here. Build from here. This is the one thing worth examining, and it will bear the weight of your examination, which is the first thing you have found in a long time that will.

# Chapter Thirty: Grace, the Doctrine You Never Actually Believed

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I want to make a claim that will sound insulting until I explain it, which is that most of us who grew up in the church never actually believed in grace, not really, not in the marrow, and that the discovery of grace, the real thing, is often something that happens on the far side of deconstruction rather than before it, which is one of the strange mercies hidden in the whole painful process. You may have had the word grace your entire life. You may have sung about it, the amazing grace that saved a wretch, and meant it as far as you understood it. But I am going to argue that the faith you were handed almost certainly corrupted grace back into a transaction, added conditions to the unconditional, turned the free gift into a wage, and that you have been living under a counterfeit grace that looked like the real thing but functioned as its opposite, and that finding the real thing may be the best gift the far side has to give you.

Here is how the counterfeit works, and see if you recognize it. You were told that salvation is by grace, a free gift, not earned, and then, in the very next breath or the next sermon or the unspoken atmosphere of the community, you were told all the things you had to do to keep it, or to prove you had it, or to not lose it. You had to believe correctly, and the believing became a work. You had to behave, and the behaving became the real currency. You had to belong, to be in, to affirm the right things and avoid the wrong things, and belonging became conditional on performance. And so grace, which was announced as free, was in practice metered out according to your compliance, and

you learned, without anyone quite saying it, that God's acceptance of you rose and fell with your performance, that you were more loved on the days you did well and less loved on the days you failed, and this is not grace, this is a transaction with grace-language painted over it, and you have been exhausting yourself trying to earn a thing you were told was free.

The exhaustion is the tell. If you grew up in the church and you are tired, bone-tired, tired in a way that rest does not fix, there is a good chance that the tiredness is the fruit of the counterfeit grace, the endless labor of trying to be acceptable to a God you were told accepted you freely but who seemed, in practice, to keep raising the bar. The counterfeit grace produces exhausted people, because it puts the weight of your acceptance back on your own shoulders while telling you the weight has been lifted, which is the cruelest possible arrangement, the weight and the lie about the weight together. And when a person deconstructs, part of what they are often fleeing, without having words for it, is this exhaustion, this endless treadmill of trying to earn an acceptance that was supposedly free, and they experience leaving the faith as finally getting off the treadmill, finally being allowed to rest, and they do not realize that what they were fleeing was not grace but the counterfeit of grace, and that the real thing, had they ever met it, was the very rest they left in order to find.

Let me tell you what the real thing is, because you may never have heard it stated without the conditions immediately reattached. The real grace is this. God's acceptance of you is not a response to anything you do. It does not rise when you perform and fall when you fail. It was settled before you were born, settled at the cross, settled in the character of a God who loved you while you were still His enemy, and there is nothing you can do to increase it and nothing you can do to decrease it, because it

was never based on your doing in the first place. You are not more loved on your good days. You are not less loved on your bad days. The love is not a response to you at all, it is a fact about God, about His character, about the crucified God who died for the ungodly, which means He died for you at your worst and not at your best, which means your worst was already included, already covered, already loved through, before you ever tried to be good enough. That is grace, and if it does not sound almost too good to be true, almost irresponsible, almost dangerous, then you have not yet heard it, because the real thing has always sounded exactly that scandalous, which is why the church keeps domesticating it back into a transaction, because the real thing is frightening in its freedom.

I have to confess that I preached the counterfeit for years, and this is one of my deepest regrets, because grace is the center and I corrupted the center. I preached grace and then immediately reattached the conditions, told people it was free and then handed them the bill, and I did it because the free thing frightened me, because I worried that if people really believed their acceptance did not depend on their performance they would stop performing, would sin freely, would take the grace as license. This is the oldest fear about grace and it is the fear that always drives the church to corrupt it, and Paul faced the exact same fear and answered it, when people asked whether we should sin more so grace could abound more, and his answer was not to reattach the conditions but to say that a person who has really met grace does not want to, that grace, received, produces not license but love, that the fear driving the corruption is based on a misunderstanding of what grace does to a person who actually receives it. I did not trust that. I hedged the grace with conditions to keep people in line, and in doing so I gave them the exhausting counterfeit and withheld the resting real



thing, and some of them left to find the rest, and the rest was there all along in the very thing I was corrupting.

Here is why this belongs in a book about deconstruction, and why I have saved it for near the end. The discovery of real grace is often what makes the rebuilt faith not just possible but joyful, because the rebuilt faith, if it is built on real grace, is built on rest rather than labor, on being accepted rather than trying to become acceptable, and this changes everything about how it feels to believe. The old faith was heavy because it was a performance, a constant effort to earn what you were told was free. The new faith, built on real grace, is light in a way the old one never was, not because it asks less of your life, it may ask more, but because it has removed the crushing weight of trying to earn your acceptance, and put in its place the rest of already being accepted, so that whatever you now do, you do out of the security of being loved rather than in the desperate hope of becoming lovable. That is the yoke Jesus called easy and the burden He called light, and it is not the absence of a yoke, it is a yoke worn by someone who is already accepted, which is a completely different thing from the yoke worn by someone trying to earn acceptance, though from outside they can look the same.

*You were told grace was free and then handed the bill. The exhaustion you are fleeing was never grace. It was the counterfeit of grace, and the real thing is rest.*

So if you are deconstructing partly to escape the exhaustion, partly to get off the treadmill of earning an acceptance that was supposedly free, I want you to consider that what you are fleeing was never grace but its counterfeit, and that the real thing, the resting thing, the scandalously free thing, is not what you are

leaving but what you have never yet fully met. Do not throw out grace with the counterfeit of grace. The works-righteousness, the conditions, the treadmill, the metered acceptance that rose and fell with your performance, throw all of that out, it is idol, it is the corruption of the center. But underneath the corruption is the real center, the announcement that you are loved with a love that does not depend on you, that was settled before you were born and cannot be increased by your success or decreased by your failure, that met you at your worst and loved you through it, and that offers you not a better performance but rest from performing altogether. That grace is the load-bearing center of the faith that holds, and most of us never actually believed it, and finding it, really finding it, is often the best thing that deconstruction, painful as it is, finally clears the ground to receive.

# Chapter Thirty-One: What You Keep and What You Leave

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We are near the end, and I owe you something practical, a way of sorting, because I have spent this whole book insisting that some things must be torn down and some things must be kept, and it is time to gather that into something you can actually use when you are standing in the rubble trying to decide what to carry out and what to leave behind. This is not a checklist, because a checklist would be its own kind of idol, the reduction of a living discernment to a mechanical rule. But it is a way of thinking, a set of questions to hold each thing up against, so that you are not sorting at random or by mood but by principles that can bear examination. Because the great danger of deconstruction is not that you tear things down, it is that you tear down without discernment, that you leave the gift and keep the wrapping, or worse, that you tear down everything indiscriminately and walk out with nothing at all.

The first question to hold each thing up against is the one I gave you early on. Is this claimed by the church across all its times and places, or is it local to my culture, my century, my tribe. The things that are claimed everywhere the church has ever existed, the resurrection, the crucified God, grace, the love stronger than death, these are candidates for the gift, the load-bearing center, and you should be very slow to tear them down, because their presence across every culture the faith has entered is a strong sign that they are the thing itself and not its wrapping. The things that are local, that appear only in your particular version of the faith, a political alignment, a style of music, a set of cultural

rules, a certainty about matters the wider church has held many views on, these are candidates for the wrapping, and you can tear them down with much less fear, because their locality is a sign that they were never the center. This one question will sort a great deal. Hold each thing up against the whole church across all time, and see whether it is a stranger there or at home.

The second question is the one about control. Does this thing offer me control, or does it ask me to trust what I cannot control. The things that offered you control, certainty that never has to trust in the dark, political power that seizes the kingdom by force, institutional belonging that makes you safe through compliance, a manageable god who rewards your obedience with safety, these are the idols, and their offer of control is the tell, and you should tear them down, because control is what idols sell and the living God never does. The things that ask you to trust what you cannot control, a crucified God you cannot use or manage, a grace you cannot earn, a resurrection you cannot prove but that will not stop confronting you, a love you must receive rather than command, these are candidates for the gift, and their refusal of control is the tell in the opposite direction, the mark of the real thing, which never offers you the mastery that idols promise. Hold each thing up and ask what it offers. If it offers control, be suspicious. If it asks for trust, look closer, because trust is the currency of the real.

The third question is about the direction it moves you, toward love or toward fear. The faith you were handed contained both, a stream of love and a stream of fear, and they were tangled together, and part of the sorting is separating them. The things that moved you toward fear, the hell that was a leash, the God whose acceptance rose and fell with your performance, the constant anxiety of never being sure you had done enough, these

are corruptions, and the fear they produced is the tell, because the God revealed in Christ is a God who casts out fear, whose perfect love drives it out, and a thing in your faith that produces fear rather than love is a thing that has departed from the center, whatever its pedigree. The things that moved you toward love, toward a security that freed you to love others, toward a rest that made you generous, toward a being-loved that overflowed into loving, these are near the center, because love is the direction the whole thing was always heading, the fulfillment of the law, the greatest of the abiding three, the very nature of the God the faith describes. Hold each thing up and ask which direction it moves you. Toward fear, be suspicious. Toward love, look closer.

Let me apply this to some specifics, because the principles are useless if I do not show them working. The certainty about the age of the earth. Local to a recent culture, offers the control of never having to say I do not know, produces fear of the evidence. Leave it. The belief that God loves you regardless of your performance. Claimed across the whole church, asks you to trust what you cannot control or earn, moves you toward love and rest. Keep it. The political alignment fused to the gospel. Local to your time and place, offers the control of power, produces fear and enmity toward the other side. Leave it. The resurrection. Claimed everywhere, asks you to trust an event you cannot control or prove, and, received, moves you toward the love that stops fearing death. Keep it. The shame about your body. Not even good wrapping, a thing put in the box that was never supposed to be there, offers the control of self-condemnation, produces nothing but fear. Leave it, and leave it fast. You see how the questions work. They do not decide for you, but they sort the pile into things you can examine rather than a mass you must accept or reject whole.

I want to warn you against two errors in the sorting, because both are common and both are fatal. The first error is keeping too much, the failure of nerve that, frightened by how much is coming down, grabs the wrapping along with the gift and carries out the whole undifferentiated mass, rebuilding the fragile fused thing that fell, and scheduling the next collapse. This is the error of the person who cannot bear to lose anything and so loses the chance to build something that holds. The second error is the opposite, leaving too much, the failure of discernment that, having found that some of it was wrapping, concludes that all of it was wrapping, and walks out of the rubble carrying nothing, into the empty field, having thrown out the gift with the box because sorting was too hard and rejection was easier. This is the error of the person who cannot bear the patient work of discernment and so takes the shortcut of rejecting everything, and calls the shortcut honesty when it is really exhaustion. Both errors avoid the actual work, which is the slow, painful, one-thing-at-a-time sorting, and there is no shortcut around it, in either direction.

*Do not carry out the whole undifferentiated mass, and do not walk out carrying nothing. Sort the pile. It is slow, and it is the only honest way.*

So sort the pile. Take the mass of your inherited faith and pull it apart one piece at a time, and hold each piece up against the three questions. Is it claimed across the whole church or local to my tribe. Does it offer control or ask for trust. Does it move me toward fear or toward love. And let the answers guide you, not mechanically, because discernment is more than a formula, but honestly, refusing both the failure of nerve that keeps too much and the failure of discernment that leaves too much. This is the work of reconstruction, and it is slow, and it cannot be rushed,

and it cannot be shortcut in either direction, and at the end of it you will be holding a smaller and truer and more load-bearing thing than the mass you started with, the gift without the wrapping, the center without the corruption, the faith that holds without the faith that fell. That is what you keep. Everything else you can leave, and leaving it is not the loss of your faith. It is the finding of it, the finding of the small true thing that was buried in the packaging the whole time, waiting for someone patient enough to sort the pile and honest enough to keep only what was real.

## Chapter Thirty-Two: Doubt Will Not Leave, and That Is Well

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I have to correct an impression this book may have accidentally given, because I have written about the wilderness and the rebuilding as though doubt were a stage you pass through and leave behind, a country you emigrate from into the settled land of a new faith, and this is not quite true, and the untruth of it could hurt you, so I have to fix it before the end. Doubt does not leave. Not entirely, not permanently, not for anyone I have ever known who thinks honestly, including me. The rebuilt faith is not a faith without doubt. It is a faith that has made peace with doubt, that has stopped treating doubt as an enemy to be defeated and started treating it as a companion to be lived with, and this is a crucial difference, because if you expect the doubt to disappear you will experience its return as a failure, a relapse, a sign that the rebuilding did not work, when in fact the return of doubt is not a failure of the rebuilt faith but a feature of any honest faith held by a finite mind.

Let me tell you the truth about my own faith now, on the far side of everything I have described, because you deserve honesty and not a triumphant testimony that hides the ongoing struggle. I still doubt. There are still mornings when the whole thing seems unlikely, when the arguments I once found compelling seem thin, when the silence of God is loud, when I catch myself, a pastor, wondering whether any of it is true. The doubt did not leave when I rebuilt. It came with me into the new house, and it lives here still, and I have stopped expecting it to move out. What changed is not that the doubt disappeared but that it



stopped being a crisis, stopped threatening to bring the whole house down, because the house is no longer built on the certainty that the doubt attacks. It is built on trust in a person, and trust can coexist with doubt the way a long marriage coexists with the occasional cold morning where you wonder, for a moment, whether you still know the person beside you, and then you get up and make the coffee and love them anyway, and the doubt passes and the marriage holds, because the marriage was never built on never having a cold morning.

This is why I have insisted, all through the book, that doubt is not the opposite of faith, and now I can say why it matters so much for the long haul. If doubt were the opposite of faith, then the return of doubt would be the return of unfaith, and every doubting morning would be a spiritual emergency, and you would live in terror of your own mind, forever fleeing the questions, forever trying to shore up a certainty that will not stay shored up because you are a finite creature contemplating an infinite God. But if doubt is not the opposite of faith, if the opposite of faith is certainty on one side and indifference on the other and doubt is something else entirely, a companion that can walk alongside trust, then the return of doubt is not an emergency, it is just the weather, and you can hold your faith through it the way you hold a marriage through a cold morning, not by pretending the coldness is not real but by knowing that the relationship is bigger than the coldness and will outlast it. The rebuilt faith is not the faith that never doubts. It is the faith that has stopped being destroyed by doubting.

There is even a gift in the persistence of doubt, though it took me a long time to see it, and I want to name it because it will help you receive your own ongoing doubt as something other than a burden. The persistence of doubt keeps faith honest. It keeps you

from calcifying back into the certainty that was the original problem, from rebuilding the very idol of certainty this whole book has been tearing down. A faith that had fully vanquished doubt would be a faith that had stopped listening, stopped questioning, stopped being a living relationship and become a settled opinion, and the settled opinion is exactly the dead thing you were right to leave. The doubt that stays is the sign that your faith is still alive, still engaged, still a real relationship with a real and mysterious God rather than a fixed conclusion about a distant idea. The people whose doubt has entirely disappeared have not always arrived at a stronger faith. Sometimes they have arrived at a deader one, having traded the living struggle for the peace of no longer thinking. Your persistent doubt is the price of a living faith, and it is a price worth paying, because the alternative is not a better faith but a deader one.

I think of the great believers again, the ones I mentioned earlier, because their example is the proof that lifelong doubt and deep faith are not enemies. Mother Teresa doubted for decades and served faithfully the whole time. The father in Mark doubted in the very moment of his belief and was not turned away. The Psalmists doubted and accused and complained and were canonized. These are not the faith's failures who managed to hang on despite their doubt. They are the faith's exemplars, and their doubt was not the thing they overcame on the way to faith but the very texture of the faith they had, a faith woven through with doubt, a belief that carried its unbelief with it into the presence of God and was received there. If lifelong doubt disqualified a person from deep faith, the church would have to strike its own saints from the rolls. Instead it canonized them, doubt and all, which tells you that the faith the church actually honors, when it is being honest, is not the doubtless certainty it often demands but the doubting trust its deepest examples

actually lived.

So let me set you free from an expectation that would otherwise crush you. You do not have to arrive at a place where the doubt is gone. That place does not exist, not for honest people, not on this side of seeing face to face, and every promise that it exists is setting you up for a despair when the doubt returns, as it will. What you can arrive at is a place where the doubt no longer threatens to bring the house down, where it has become a companion rather than an enemy, where you can doubt in the morning and make the coffee and love the God you are not entirely sure of anyway, and where the doubting itself becomes, strangely, a part of the faith rather than its negation, the sign that you are still in a real relationship with a real and mysterious God rather than clinging to a dead certainty about a distant idea. That is the faith that holds. Not the faith that never doubts, but the faith that has learned to doubt and trust at the same time, to say with the father in Mark, in the same breath, without resolving the contradiction, I believe, and help my unbelief, and to find that both halves of the sentence are welcome in the presence of Christ.

*The rebuilt faith is not the faith that never doubts. It is the faith that has stopped being destroyed by doubting.*

I find this, in the end, one of the most freeing truths I know, and I want to leave it with you as a gift rather than a disappointment. You are not aiming at a doubtless certainty, and you can stop exhausting yourself trying to reach it, and you can stop despairing every time the doubt comes back, because the doubt coming back was never the failure you feared it was. It is the weather of an honest faith, and honest faith has weather, and the weather passes and returns and passes again, and through all of it

the house stands, because the house is built on rock, on trust in a person, and not on the cloudless sky of a certainty you could never have sustained. Let the doubt come. Let it be your companion. Make the coffee. Love the God you are not always sure of. Say the honest prayer. And know that the faith you are living, the doubting, trusting, honest faith that carries its unbelief into the presence of Christ, is not a lesser thing than the certainty you lost. It is a greater thing, and a truer thing, and the only kind of faith, in the end, that a finite creature contemplating an infinite God was ever actually able to have.

## Chapter Thirty-Three: The Slowness of the Return

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I have to say something about time, because everything in this book takes longer than you want it to, and the failure to understand this is one of the great destroyers of people in the middle of it. We live in a culture of the fast, of the immediate, of the problem solved by evening, and we bring these expectations to the deepest and slowest process a human soul can undergo, and then we despair when it does not resolve on our timeline, and the despair, not the process, is often what finally defeats people. So I want to spend a chapter defending slowness, insisting on it, because the return, if it comes, comes slowly, and if you expect it fast you will give up in the exact middle of the slow thing that was actually working.

Consider how long the biblical processes take, because the Bible is remarkably honest about time in a way our culture is not. Israel is in the wilderness for forty years, not forty days. Abraham waits decades for the promised son. Joseph is in prison for years before the dream comes true. The exile lasts seventy years. And the deepest process of all, the one at the center of the whole story, takes three days, and I want you to notice that even three days was too long for the disciples, that Saturday, the day between the crucifixion and the resurrection, the day of waiting in the tomb's shadow with no sign that Sunday was coming, was for them a day of total despair, because they did not know it was only a day, they thought it was forever, they thought Friday was the end. That is where you often are. You are in Saturday, in the waiting, in the time between the death of the old and the

resurrection of the new, and you do not know it is Saturday, you think it is the end, because from inside Saturday you cannot see Sunday coming. The slowness is not a sign that nothing is happening. It is the shape of the deepest things, which do not resolve on the timeline of a culture that has forgotten how to wait.

Let me tell you about the slowness of my own return, because I have been vague about the timeline and I want to be specific now, so you do not imagine it was faster than it was. My faith came apart over a period of a couple of years, quietly, in the way I described in the opening. And the rebuilding, the finding of the faith that holds, was not a moment, not a breakthrough, not a single night where it all came back. It took years. It took longer than the falling apart had taken. There were long stretches where nothing seemed to be happening, where I was just in the wilderness, receiving the daily manna, praying the honest prayer, showing up to a faith I could barely feel, and I could not have told you, in those stretches, that anything was being built, because it did not feel like building, it felt like waiting, it felt like Saturday. And only looking back, from the far side, can I see that the waiting was the building, that the God who felt absent was doing the deepest work in the very silence I took as evidence of His absence, that the slowness was not the failure of the process but the process itself. I could not see it from inside. You will not be able to see it from inside either. That is what makes the slowness so hard, that it does its work invisibly, so that from within it looks exactly like nothing happening.

This is why I have to warn you against the two things people do to escape the slowness, because both of them abort the very process that would have saved them. The first is to rush the rebuilding, to grab at a fast resolution, to seize the first certainty that offers itself just to escape the unbearable openness of the

waiting. People do this. They come out of the wilderness too early, having rushed to a new certainty, and they build on sand again because they could not tolerate the slowness of building on rock, which requires waiting for the ground to be found rather than grabbing at the first solid-seeming thing. The second is to give up, to conclude from the slowness that nothing is coming, that the silence is final, that the empty field is where this ends, and to walk out of Saturday convinced it is Friday's permanent aftermath, never knowing that Sunday was one day away. Both of these are failures to endure the slowness, and both of them forfeit the return, one by rushing past it and one by quitting before it, and both are driven by the same intolerance of the waiting, the same refusal to be in Saturday without knowing when Sunday comes.

So how do you endure a slowness whose end you cannot see, a Saturday that might be one day or might, for all you can tell from inside it, be forever. You endure it the way the faithful have always endured the wilderness, not by knowing when it ends but by receiving the day you are in. This is the manna discipline again, and it is the only discipline that works for the slowness, because it does not require you to see the end, it requires only that you receive today's portion, today's small mercy, today's single reason to keep going, and trust that tomorrow's will come when tomorrow comes. You cannot endure the whole wilderness at once, because the whole wilderness is too much and its end is invisible. You can endure today, this one day, with its one portion of manna, its one line of a Psalm that holds, its one moment where the crucified God seems briefly real, its one small refusal to give up. And then tomorrow you do it again. And the days accumulate, invisibly, into the slow work that you cannot see from inside, and one day, though you cannot schedule it or force it or predict it, you look up and find that Saturday has become

Sunday, not because you made it happen but because Sunday was always coming, and the waiting was the only way to get there.

I want to be honest that I cannot promise your Saturday becomes Sunday, because I have promised throughout not to flatter, and a guarantee of the resurrection on the far side of every wilderness would be a flattery and a lie. Some Saturdays, in this life, do not visibly become Sundays. Some people wait in the dark and the light does not come, or does not come in the time we can see, and I will not pretend otherwise, because pretending otherwise is the cheap comfort this book has refused from the first page. What I can tell you is narrower and truer. The slowness is not evidence against the return. Saturday feels exactly like the end even when it is not, and the fact that you cannot see Sunday from inside Saturday tells you nothing about whether Sunday is coming, because you could not have seen it from inside Saturday either way. So the slowness, the invisibility, the feeling that nothing is happening, none of these are evidence that nothing is happening, and you must not let them talk you into rushing or quitting, because the very process that would save you is the one that feels, from inside, like nothing at all.

*You are in Saturday, and Saturday feels exactly like the end, even when Sunday is one day away.*

So be slow. Give the return the time it needs, which is more time than you want to give it, more time than the culture will tolerate, more time than feels reasonable while you are waiting. Do not rush the rebuilding into a fast certainty that will be sand. Do not quit the wilderness one day before Sunday because Saturday convinced you it was Friday forever. Receive the day you are in, today's manna, today's small mercy, and then do it again



tomorrow, and let the days accumulate into a work you cannot see. The slowness is not your enemy. The slowness is the shape of the deepest things, the shape of a wilderness that formed a people, the shape of a Saturday that held the whole waiting world between the cross and the empty tomb. You are in that shape now, in the slow middle of it, and you cannot see the end, and that is exactly what being in it feels like, and it is not evidence that there is no end. Wait. Receive today. It is the hardest and the truest thing, and it is the only way anyone has ever crossed from Saturday to Sunday, which is to say, one slow, invisible, faithful day at a time.

## Chapter Thirty-Four: The God With Scars

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We have come nearly to the end, and I want to gather the whole book into a single figure, because everything I have argued keeps returning to Him, and it is time to look at Him directly and let Him be the answer that He is. Through every chapter, under every question, at the bottom of every tearing down, there has been one figure who would not fall, one image that survived when the idols were rubble, and He is the crucified and risen God, the God with scars, and I want to end the argument of this book by showing you why He, and only He, is the God who can be found on the far side of an honest deconstruction, the God who does not merely survive the fire but was waiting in it the whole time.

Think about what the resurrection does to the wounds. When the risen Christ appears to the disciples, He is not a smoothed-over, restored, pre-crucifixion body with the damage erased. He still has the scars. He shows them the holes in His hands and His side, He invites Thomas to touch them, and this is one of the strangest and most important details in the whole story and we rush past it constantly. The resurrection did not undo the crucifixion. It did not rewind history to before the wounds. It carried the wounds through death and out the other side, transformed but not erased, so that the risen God is forever the God with scars, the God who bears in His resurrected body the marks of what was done to Him. And this tells you something about what resurrection is, in the only case that matters, and therefore about what it might be for you. Resurrection is not the

erasure of the wound. It is the wound carried through death and transfigured, still visible, no longer bleeding, become somehow the very sign of the victory rather than its contradiction.

This is why He is the God who can be found on the far side of your deconstruction, and no other god can. Every other god that has been offered to humanity is a god without scars, a god above suffering, untouched, serene, explaining pain from a safe distance or ignoring it altogether. And a god without scars cannot help you, because your wounds are real and a god who has no wounds of his own can only ever stand outside yours, offering explanations you did not ask for, comfort from a distance you cannot cross. But the God with scars is different. He does not stand outside your suffering. He has His own. He was failed by the institution, betrayed by His friends, tortured by the powerful, abandoned in the dark, and He cried out the lament from the cross, my God my God why have you forsaken me, so that when you bring Him your wound, your abandonment, your unanswered prayer, your silence, He does not meet you with an explanation. He meets you by showing you His own scars, and saying, without words, I know, I was there, I am there, this place you are in I have been in, and I did not stay out of it, I came all the way down into it, all the way to the bottom, so that you would never be at the bottom alone.

Let me connect this to every hard question in this book, because it is the answer to all of them, not as an argument but as a presence. You asked about the harm the church did, and the answer is a God who was Himself harmed by religious institutions, tried by the church of His day, executed with its approval, so that He is not the ally of the church that wounded you but its victim alongside you. You asked about the cruel-seeming God, and the answer is a God who, when He finally

showed His full face, was not the war-god slaughtering His enemies but the crucified God being slaughtered by them, absorbing the cruelty of the world into His own body rather than inflicting it. You asked about the silence, and the answer is a God who Himself endured the silence on the cross, whose deepest forsakenness hid the salvation of the world. You asked whether a faith could survive suffering, and the answer is a God who did not merely survive suffering but was transfigured through it, carrying His scars into resurrection as the very signs of His triumph. Every question this book has raised is answered not by a proposition but by this figure, the God with scars, who does not resolve your suffering from a distance but enters it and bears it and carries it through death into a resurrection that does not erase the wounds but transfigures them.

And here is the final thing, the thing that this whole book has been walking toward, the reason the crucified God is not just an answer to your suffering but a promise about your faith. If resurrection is the wound carried through death and transfigured rather than erased, then that is the shape of what can happen to your fallen faith. Your faith died. I have said from the first chapter that it needed to die, that you must not resuscitate the corpse, that resurrection is not resuscitation. And now I can tell you what resurrection is, because I can show you His body. Resurrection is your faith carried through its death and out the other side, transformed, still bearing the marks of what it went through, no longer the pre-crucifixion faith that could not survive contact with the world, but a risen faith, scarred, transfigured, that has been through death and cannot die again in the same way, because it has already died once and come out the other side. The faith that holds is a scarred faith. It bears the marks of its own deconstruction the way the risen Christ bears the marks of the cross, and the scars are not the contradiction of its life but

the very sign of it, the proof that it went all the way down into death and came back, which is the only kind of faith that can finally hold, because it is the only kind that has already survived the worst.

So when people ask you, on the far side, whether you have the same faith you started with, you can tell them the truth, which is the truth of the risen body. No. It is not the same faith. It went through death. It bears the scars. It is not the smooth, unwounded, pre-crucifixion faith you began with, and you would not want that faith back if you saw clearly what it was, a faith that had never been tested, that could not have survived what yours survived. What you have instead is a risen faith, scarred and transfigured, that has been to the bottom and come back, that carries its deconstruction in its body the way Christ carries the cross in His, no longer as a wound that bleeds but as a mark of victory. That faith is not a lesser thing than the one that fell. It is a greater thing, a risen thing, and its scars are not its shame but its glory, the visible proof that it went all the way through the death that the untested faith was too fragile to survive, and came out the other side alive.

*Every other god stands outside your suffering, explaining it. Only the God with scars comes all the way down into it, so that you are never at the bottom alone.*

This is the God I found at the bottom of my own deconstruction, when the idols were rubble and I could not make Him fall, and He is the God I am pointing you toward through this whole book, not the manageable god of control who died in the rooms of my suffering and needed to die, but the God with scars, who was waiting at the bottom, who had gotten there before me, whose wounds matched my wounds, whose forsakenness had

already gone deeper than my own. He is the God who can be found on the far side of an honest tearing down, because He is the only God who was never threatened by it, having already conceded everything the tearing down is based on, the suffering and the silence and the cruelty and the abandonment, having taken all of it into His own body and carried it through death into a resurrection that bears the scars forever. Find Him. He is not in the rubble of your idols, which are only rubble. He is standing beyond the rubble, with holes in His hands, having waited for you to tear down everything that stood between you and Him, so that at last, in the cleared ground, with all the false gods fallen, you could finally see the true one, the God with scars, who was there the whole time, at the bottom, where He always is.